



Hindustan Times

BARAMATI: TRAINER AIRCRAFT VEERS OFF RUNWAY DURING FLIGHT EXERCISE

Neha LM Tripathi and Shrinivas Deshpande

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/PUNE: A private training aircraft veered off the runway at Baramati Airport on Sunday during a flying exercise, the civil aviation ministry said on Sunday. No one was injured in the incident. This was the second aircraft accident at the airport since Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader and former Maharashtra deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar's plane crash in January. HT on Sunday reported that the state government is set to clear a ₹100-crore upgrade plan for the Baramati Airport. →P6

COULD HAVE DIED, SAYS MAMATA AFTER MOB HURLS STONES, SHOES, MUD AT CAR

KOLKATA: Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Sunday said that a mob hurled stones, mud and shoes at her car during a visit to North 24 Parganas district to meet the family of a TMC worker who had died in police custody. Banerjee blamed the BJP for the incident and said that she "could have died". The BJP rejected the charge, with chief minister Suvedu Adhikari saying that the victim's family said they don't want any interference from Banerjee. →P5



Urban squalor shrouds Delhi's Lodhi-era tombs

→P2

Modi cheers CWG champions



Prime Minister Narendra Modi poses with (from left) weightlifters Rishikanta Singh, Bindyarani Devi and Mirabai Chanu, and boxer Jadumani Singh in New Delhi on Sunday during a meeting with the medalists from the recently held Commonwealth Games (CWG). More coverage on page 12 PMO

PM HAILS ATHLETES: 'JO KHELEGA, WO KHELEGA'
The PM shared a clip of his interaction with the medalists on Instagram as he praised them for making the country proud. "Jo khelega, woh khelega (The one who plays, will blossom. Always cheer for Bharat)", Modi said.

PROUD TO MEET PM: GOLD-WINNING BOXER
Boxer Sakshi Chaudhary, who won gold in the women's 51kg event, said she was proud to meet the Prime Minister. Modi "welcomed the medalists from the Games and we are feeling very proud of this", she said.

INDIA MARKS A GIANT LEAP AT U20 WORLDS
Basant Kumar Meghwal became the first Indian to win a medal in high jump at the World Athletics U20 Championships, clinching silver with a personal best of 2.21m. Shahbaz Khan won bronze in the long jump after clearing 7.84m. →P14

HPV jab, data caveats in Delhi's Lakshmi scheme

Hemani Bhandari

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Women applying for the Delhi government's Lakshmi Yojana welfare programme must ensure that children in their family are vaccinated in line with government norms, including the HPV jab for girls aged above 14, and applicants must consent to the use of their personal information for "monitoring and evaluation", according to the scheme's standard operating procedure (SOP), the latest in a long line of caveats the state prescribes for eligibility.

The protocol and application form also requires applicants to sign off on their personal data being shared "with other authorities", including "banking partners or other stakeholders associated with the scheme", as well as to undertake an online pledge for centrally backed

SOP for financial aid scheme

The scheme provides ₹2,500/month to the eldest woman aged 21-60 from a household earning less than ₹2.5L/year

- ▶ Vaccination of children, including HPV for girls
- ▶ Consent to use of personal information for 'monitoring and evaluation'
- ▶ Consent to sharing of personal data with 'banking

- partners', other stakeholders
- ▶ Online pledge for social causes such as 'Ek Pedh Maa ke Naam', 'Swachh Bharat'
- ▶ Families with pregnant/lactating women to ensure registration on POSHAN Tracker

social causes such as "Ek Pedh Maa ke Naam", "Swachh Bharat" and "No To Single-Use Plastic", or other programmes prescribed by the government.

"All children should be vaccinated as per Government prescribed schedule in the family, including HPV vaccine (more than 14-year-old girl child)", says the SOP, in the "Responsibilities of Beneficiaries & Condi-

tionality for Beneficiary Family" section, which lays down a range of requirements for applicants.

Women are required to sign an undertaking on similar lines in the application form: "I will ensure that all children in the family are vaccinated, including the HPV vaccine for girls above 14 years of age."

continued on →9

BCCI TO SEEK NOD FROM GOVT FOR TOUR TO B'DESH

MUMBAI: The BCCI is set to seek clearance from the government for a white-ball tour of Bangladesh amid a strain in ties between the two countries. "Only if it [government] gives a nod would the tour go ahead," a BCCI official said. India were originally scheduled to play three ODIs and three T20Is in Bangladesh in 2025 but the tour was put on hold amid political tensions between the two countries. →P3

INDIAN WANTED FOR U.S. WOMAN'S MURDER ARRESTED

NEW DELHI: A 20-year-old Indian national studying in the US allegedly killed his girlfriend before he was caught in Germany trying to escape, the New York Post reported on Sunday. Varun Batigari allegedly strangled 19-year-old Julissa Rubi Salazar inside her apartment near the University of Arizona in Tucson last week, the newspaper cited the Tucson Police Department as saying. →P11

PROTESTS IN VIZAG AND THANE AGAINST MEGA DATA CENTRES

Soumya Chatterjee

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's push to become an Artificial Intelligence powerhouse is facing growing local resistance, with residents in Thane and Visakhapatnam protesting large data centre projects over concerns that they could put additional pressure on land, electricity and water resources. Similar protests have also taken place globally. →P8

SHARDA UNIVERSITY

Beyond Boundaries

STAR ALUMNI

Sweta Kumari
B.Tech - CSE
Microsoft

Chetan Sahal
BBA
Reliance Industries Limited

Aakriti Kumari
B.Sc - Biotech
accenture

COME BE A PART OF INDIA'S TRULY AI ENABLED UNIVERSITY

- Generative AI Integrated into Teaching & Learning
- NVIDIA & Industry-Partnered AI Learning Ecosystem
- Real-World AI Projects & AI Powered Innovation Labs

Admissions Open Against Few Lapsed / Vacant Seats

B.Tech.
Biotechnology | Food Technology
Computer Science & Engineering (CSE)
• AI & Machine Learning - AI & Data Science
• Cyber Security & Forensics with EC-Council - AI Enabled Fintech
• Full Stack Development with Xebia
Computer Science & Medical Engineering (AI)
Electrical and Electronics Engineering (EEE)
Electronics & Communication Engineering
Electronics & Computer Engineering
Electronics & Computer Engineering - AI & ML
Mechanical Engineering | Civil Engineering

Bachelor of Computer Applications (BCA)
• AI & ML - Cloud Computing & IoT - Cyber Security

B.Sc.
• Biotechnology - Data Science & Analytics - Physics - Chemistry
• Mathematics - Biochemistry - Zoology - Microbiology
• Food Science & Technology - Geography & Geoinformatics
• Nutrition & Dietetics - Electronic Science - Environmental Science
• Animation, VFX and Gaming Design - Forensic Science

B.A. | B.A. (Hons./Research)
• Psychology - English - Economics - History
• Political Science - Sociology
BBA | BBA (Hons./Research)
• Finance & Accounting (with ACCA, UK)
BBA LL.B. (Hons.) Integrated | B.A. LL.B. (Hons.) Integrated

B.Com. | B.Com. (Hons./Research)
• B.Com. - International Accounting & Finance (with ACCA, UK)

ALL INFORMATION JUST A CLICK AWAY

Ask Sharda AI www.sharda.ac.in/sai

THE WORLD IS HERE. WHERE ARE YOU?

Campus: Plot No. 32, 34, Knowledge Park-II, Greater Noida (Delhi-NCR) | **0120-4570000**

www.sharda.ac.in

UPTO 100% SCHOLARSHIP FOR MERITORIOUS STUDENTS

NUMBER THEORY

Pilgrimage and numbers: What data says about Kanwar Yatra

By Abhishek Jha

The Kanwar Yatra is one of the longest and most public forms of religiosity seen in the Hindi-speaking states of the Gangetic plains. The pilgrimage, which takes place in the Hindu month of Shrawan and is currently underway, lasts for a few weeks and often creates news for reasons that are far removed from religion. The ritual seems to be attracting more people every year, along with the seasonal philanthropy which emerges along its route. Is it possible to capture all of this quantitatively? Two government surveys – one on domestic tourism and another one-time use – can help us do that.

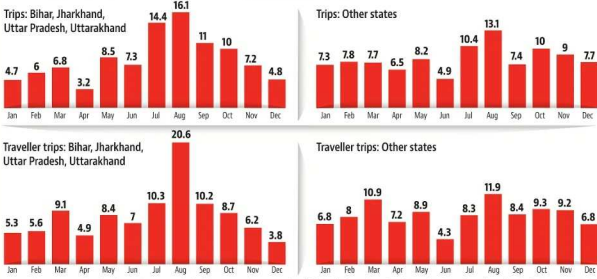


1 How important is Kanwar Yatra among religious trips in India?

The last domestic tourism survey was conducted in July 2014-June 2015 and is now a decade old. However, it can offer at least a directional sense of the popularity of the Kanwar Yatra relative to other kinds of pilgrimages. The survey asked households if any member had undertaken an overnight trip (a trip not made regularly, lasting at least 12 hours and including the period between midnight and 5 am) in the 30/365 days preceding the survey. Pilgrimages were surveyed in the 30-day recall period, along with trips undertaken for business, social, or education and training purposes. In

the year of the survey, Shrawan was observed from July 13 to August 10, and Hindus reported a peak of pilgrimage trips in August that was not seen for the other three categories. A large part of this might simply have to do with the population weight of the four states through which the Kanwar Yatra routes run: Bihar, Jharkhand, Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand. The August peak is far more clearly defined in these states and less so in other states, especially in terms of traveller-trips, which is the number of trips multiplied by the number of members travelling.

Share of month in total trips undertaken for pilgrimage, religious activities by Hindus in 2014-15
% of total pilgrimage trips/traveller trips undertaken by the Hindus of the region



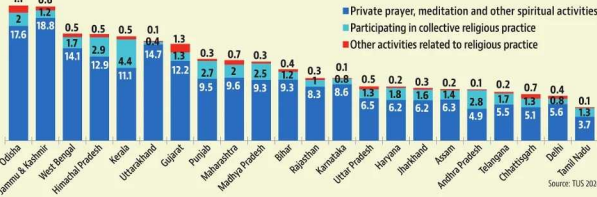
Survey was conducted in July 2014-June 2015 and asked about overnight trips completed by household members during last 30 days. Data shown here is for the leading purpose of trips. Source: Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey, NSSO 2014-15

2 Public display of religiosity does not mean kanwariya states are more religious in daily life

The scale of the Shrawan pilgrimage and its visible impact on everyday life along the routes does not mean that Hindus in states that are more likely to send kanwariyas are more religious. The average Bhari Hindu spends 10.9 minutes per day in religious activity according to the 2024 Time Use Survey, the same as the average Indian Hindu. Hindus in Uttar Pradesh and Jharkhand spend a couple of minutes less. While

Uttarakhand Hindus do rank on the higher end, they still spend about five minutes less than the Hindus in Odisha, who rank highest. More importantly, in all states, almost all of the time is spent on private prayer rather than in collective religious practices. This squares with anecdotal and qualitative explanations of the Kanwar Yatra, which attribute its popularity also to factors beyond religious practice.

Time spent per Hindu person on average in a day on religious activity in 2024 Time/person per day (minutes)



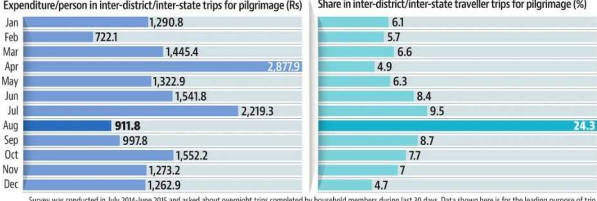
Source: TUS 2024

3 What also helps is the social subsidy on the pilgrimage

Come kanwariya season, a large number of camps come up to cater to the needs of pilgrims. This entails a degree of social subsidisation of the entire endeavour, thereby reducing the need for private spending by the person undertaking it. Even

this shows up in the government data on domestic tourism cited above. The average inter-state or inter-district pilgrimage spending in August in the survey is ₹912 per person compared to ₹1,501 in other months for Hindus of the four states.

Cost of pilgrimage among Hindus of Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Uttarakhand, and Jharkhand by month



Survey was conducted in July 2014-June 2015 and asked about overnight trips completed by household members during last 30 days. Data shown here is for the leading purpose of trip. Source: Domestic Tourism Expenditure Survey, NSSO 2014-15

Once the new domestic tourism survey is published -- it was conducted between July 2025-June 2026 -- we will know more about these trends, which perhaps have only become stronger.



Hindustan Times

FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

High electricity bill? Zero bill made possible



PM Surya Ghar:
Muft Bijli Yojana



To apply,
scan here

For more information, visit:
pmsuryaghar.gov.in
Toll Free Number: 15555



27/08/2026 12:00 PM

BRIJ BHUSHAN FACED POLITICALLY DRIVEN CHARGES; ACQUITTAL ORDER

Arnabjit Sur

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The sexual harassment allegations against former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) chief and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) parliamentarian Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh were "false", "fabricated" and levelled as part of a "deep conspiracy which seems to be politically motivated," a Delhi court said in its acquittal order, parts of which HT has seen.

DELHI COPS ISSUED RULES FOR ONLINE ACTIVITY TRACKING

Jignasa Sinha

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has standardised Internet Protocol Detail Records (IPDR) and dump-data analysis through a series of training material amid increased demand for such data during major incidents and mass gatherings. The documents were released on Saturday. A senior officer said, "We have laid out guidelines since there's a spike in IPDR analysis."

No W Asia headway as US dials down on talks

Agencies

letters@hindustantimes.com

DUBAI/WASHINGTON/CAIRO: Iran's Revolutionary Guards said on Sunday that they would not reopen the Strait of Hormuz until the United States complied with a list of demands, including paying compensation for war damage. US President Donald Trump, meanwhile, said in an interview with Axios that the US was "low-keying" it with Iran. "We are only semi-negotiating with them. We are just watching Iran with its huge inflation and the fact they have no money."

The remarks came after Iranian foreign minister Abbas Araghchi said Iran and the US are not engaged in talks and Tehran will not start them as long as Washington breaches an interim deal signed in June, adding that messages are being exchanged via intermediaries. Araghchi said a deal with Oman defining new shipping lanes in the Strait of Hormuz was in its final stages but that the waterway would only be reopened if the US agreed to pay compensation for war damage.

Still in gridlock

"We are low-keying it. We are only semi-negotiating with them. We are just watching Iran with its huge inflation and the fact they have no money... It always works out. It's like a chess game."
— DONALD TRUMP, US President



"We are not currently negotiating with the United States the exchange of messages takes place through intermediaries. The Americans were seeking to establish new routes through the Strait of Hormuz... Any violation of the MoU... is absolutely unacceptable."
— ABBAS ARAGHCHI, Iran Foreign Minister



HOUSTON ATTACK SAUDI ARAMCO OIL REFINERY
Yemen's Houthis said they attacked an oil facility Sunday in southwestern Saudi Arabia, the latest attack by the Iranian-backed rebels on the kingdom. Yahya Saree, a military spokesperson for the Houthis, said they targeted an Aramco refinery in Jazan with a drone. The attack was in response to Saudi drones breaching Yemen's airspace over the provinces of Hajjah and Saada, he said.

NETANYAHU REJECTS TRUMP'S GAZA PLAN
Israel has rejected US President Donald Trump's Board of Peace's 15-point plan for Gaza, and will not withdraw until Hamas fully disarms, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said on Sunday. Trump announced last month that there had been a breakthrough in his plan to end the war, which both Israel and Hamas agreed to last year. Israel has continued to carry out strikes on Gaza since agreeing to the ceasefire last October.

PROTESTERS IN J'KHAND PLAN ASSEMBLY MARCH; DEPLOYMENT UP

Raj Kumar

letters@hindustantimes.com

RANCHI: Protesters in Jharkhand plan to go ahead with a march to the assembly in Ranchi on Monday as the deadlock with the state government continues. Authorities have deployed additional forces, with senior police officers appealing to students to remain peaceful and warning of legal action if anyone resorts to violence during the march.

PRALHAD MEETS TOP OFFICIALS, NTA WORKING IN FOCUS

Sanjay Maurya

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Union education minister Pralhad Joshi on Sunday held a meeting with senior officials on "on matters concerning" the National Testing Agency (NTA) and discussed steps for stronger mechanisms, streamlined processes, and better student support. It was Joshi's first meeting focused on the testing body, which has been criticised over the NEET-UG paper leak.

More noise, snarls ahead: Kanwar count set to swell

Gargi Shukla and
Jignasa Sinha

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Capital lived through another sleepless night on Sunday as Kanwar Yatra trucks, double the 55db limit for residential areas during the day and 45db at night. To be sure, the use of loudspeakers at any volume is disallowed between 10pm and 6am.

Delhi Police did little to keep the blare in check, despite residents from several neighbourhoods on the Yatra route airing their concerns, especially the health effects of exposure to such volumes, coupled with the peaks of 110 decibels again around a clutch of Kanwar Yatra trucks.

HT's sound meters logged

continued on → 9



Kanwariyas on a truck near Ghaziabad. SABIR ALI/HT PHOTO

Shah likely to introduce two bills in House today

Pallavi Singhal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah is scheduled to introduce two bills — one seeking to rename Kerala as Kerala and another expanding the financing powers of the National Co-operative Development Corporation (NCDC) — in the Lok Sabha on Monday.

CENTRE GIVES ED CHIEF RAHUL NAVIN 1-YEAR EXTENSION

Neeraj Chauhan

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union government has extended the tenure of Enforcement Directorate (ED) director Rahul Navin by a year beyond August 13, according to an order issued on Sunday. A 1993-batch IRS officer, Navin, 59, joined ED as special director in 2019. He was named the agency's chief in August 2024.

ISS BAAR

SOCHNA PADEGA



Google Gemini

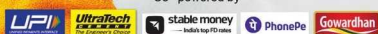
MARUTI SUZUKI

ADITYA BIRLA GROUP

Co-presented by



Co-powered by



Special partners



STARTS
TONIGHT
9PM



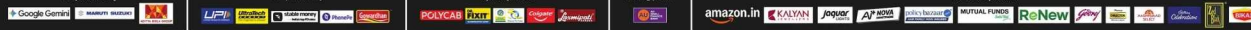
Co-presented by

Co-powered by

Special partners

Banking partner

Associate sponsors



PAGE ONE PLUS

Urban squalor swallows Lodhi-era tombs

Metres from GK-1 in south Delhi, a line of cramped lanes packed with buildings obscure four 15th century tombs, which now double up as garbage dumps and cattle sheds

Paras Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A few hundred metres from Greater Kailash-1, the neatly lined bungalows, luxury boutiques and chic bars give way to cramped lanes, skies blocked by rows of tightly packed houses and their extended balconies, tangled overhead wires, unkempt streets and piles of uncleared trash.

But hidden from sight in this congested urban village, Zamrudpur, are centuries-old slices of Delhi's past. During spot checks in June and July, HT found at least four Lodhi-era tombs listed by the Delhi government as Grade I heritage buildings, walled off by unplanned houses and, in some cases, doubling up as storerooms, cattle sheds or even garbage dumps.

The towering tombs were built by Zamrud Khan, an Afghan noble during the reign of Sikandar Lodhi in the late 15th century, and their decay is a story of Delhi's rich heritage being subsumed by the contemporary pressures of a swelling population, civic apathy and administrative disinterest.

Khan was given the *jagir* of then Kanchan Sarai for his personal use, which he renamed after himself.

In Delhi's early years, GK-1 was carpeted in farmlands that produced rich Kharif yields. The land, spread over hundreds of acres across Zamrudpur and Devli villages, was owned by about 80 farmers.

In 1955, the Centre acquired the plots as part of a large-scale acquisition plan and handed them over to DLF to carve out a residential colony. The agricultural fields became some of the most sought-after addresses in the national capital. The two villages, however, were left behind.

A left turn from Lalajpata Rai Marg, a lane leads to the *badli chaurah*—the meeting spot in a village, at the intersection of four major roads. A right turn near a Lord Shiva temple leads to the largest tomb in the village.

Almost three storeys high, the domed structure is walled off by houses on three sides, with their walls just inches away. Two private gates have been erected on either side, their arches decorated with flower pots.

Inside, the tomb is now also home to a cattle shed.

A cow and her calf, tied near the feeding area, rest beside an 8-ft-tall wall that splits the structure. The rest of the space, lit by a single bulb hanging from the 15th-century deep dome, is used as a dumpyard for furniture and construction waste.

During the spot check, the owner of the cattle objected to pictures being taken.

"This is our building. We have taken care of it for generations and will continue to do it," said the man, who declined to be identified. Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) records list the monument as a public building, with maintenance the civic body's responsibility.

MCD spokespersons did not respond to requests seeking comment.

The entry for the monument in *Delhi: The Built Heritage*, compiled by the Indian National Trust for Art and Cultural Heritage (INTACH), lists the building as "Grade A" or "Grade 1" for its archaeological value.

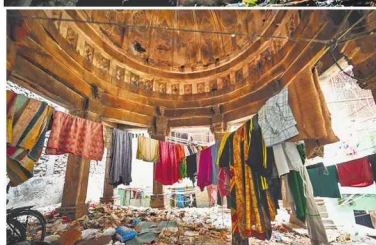
Grade A heritage designations refer to cultural properties, structures, or precincts of exceptional national, regional, or historical importance. These buildings embody top-tier architectural style, design, or have deep association with historic events and prime city landmarks. Grade 2 includes structures of regional or local importance with special architectural features, while Grade 3 comprises those that contribute to the townscape and evoke architectural, aesthetic, or sociological interest.

These monuments were documented by Zafar Hasan, then assistant superintendent of the Archaeological Survey of India, in his 1916 work *Monuments of Delhi*. The tomb is spread over a 6.58sqm area. On its north, south and east sides are recessed arches enclosing three openings.



(Above and left) Houses have cropped up around the domed structure which locals use to dry their laundry, and dump trash. The tomb is a Grade I heritage building, according to Delhi's urban development ministry. The structure was built by Zamrud Khan—an Afghan noble in the reign of Sikandar Lodhi in the late 15th century.

SANCHIT KHANNA/HT PHOTO



They once presumably looked onto fields of wheat, chickpea, cauliflowers, or tobacco. Now, the arches are blocked off, inches away from the unplastered walls of unauthorised buildings.

On the west are three *mehrab* (an arched wall) recesses, while the high dome rises from an octagonal drum. Past the *chaurah*, a left leads into a dim alley. MCD records list a tomb nearby, but its geo-coordinates do not point to any visible structure. But the eyes deceive.

A flight of stairs leads up five storeys to a rooftop. Around 20 metres below, the dome of another tomb creeps up, jostling for air with buildings plastered around it.

The dome is now the landing spot for garbage hung off balconies and windows by residents of the buildings, most of whom are tenants.

Sheila Devi, who has lived in the area for 30 years, said she watched buildings grow around the tombs. "There are five-six *chaurahs* and *gumbads*, but they are in extremely poor shape," she said.

The walls of these tombs are made of rubble masonry, finished with plaster. The pillars are mostly dressed with finely cut stone. Lodhi-era tombs traditionally used Delhi quartzite stone and red sandstone.

The third tomb is about 50m away. This one is enclosed by at least six five-storey buildings with small rooms rented out to daily wage workers. The snaking trunk of a gular tree twists around the structure, ending in a canopy above it.

Residents use the tomb as a clothesline. The raised stone platform is, like its sibling

structures, layered in trash.

This tomb is spread over a 6.58sqm area, its dome supported by 12 carved pillars of dressed stone. It rises from an octagon topped with a lotus cresting.

Anchal, a local resident, said the *gumbad* serves as a local landmark—but largely to guide guests, delivery agents and postal services. "But everyone uses it to dump their waste. It has been cleared a few times, but the garbage returns," she said.

Md Jamshed, another resident, said if the *gumbad* were cleaned and restored, it could serve as common space in a neighbourhood starved of any. "After years of neglect, it is still beautiful," he said.

HT found a fourth tomb, also packed with garbage. Its dome used as a base by one of the buildings abutting it—almost completely subsumed.

INTACH's compilation lists a fifth tomb, which HT was unable to trace. The compilation says it was illegally occupied and inaccessible, but had 12 dressed stone pillars with a lotus cresting on the dome.

A senior MCD official said the tomb may have been demolished. "We surveyed some of these tombs in April for the ongoing Supreme Court case regarding monuments, and three tombs were in poor condition with heavy encroachment, while the fourth was relatively better maintained. After assessing the required conservation work, a budget will be sought to restore them," the official said.

The official did not say why the tombs were not given even a basic clean-up.

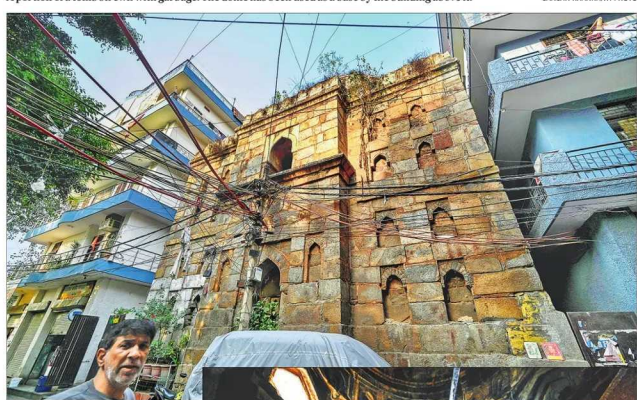
Om Prakash, a worker from Bihar who lives in Zamrudpur, said migrant laborers are forced to live in such conditions.

"A small room for ₹4,000-5,000 can be shared. During the day, I mostly stay out in search of work and need this room only to sleep in. The tombs may have value, but we have our own share of problems," he said.



A portion of a tomb strewn with garbage. The dome has been used as a base by the building above it.

SANCHIT KHANNA/HT PHOTO



(Above) A tomb sandwiched between two buildings in Zamrudpur; (Right) Cows rest inside a tomb being used as a shelter. Residents also dump furniture and construction waste inside the monument.

SANCHIT KHANNA/HT PHOTO



Another tomb surrounded by unauthorised construction and used as a dumping site.

SANCHIT KHANNA/HT PHOTO



PICK OF THE DAY

DKS in Delhi to discuss portfolios with top brass

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar reached Delhi on Sunday evening to meet the Congress central leadership over the allocation of portfolios to 19 newly inducted ministers, amid speculations that several ministers are pushing for departments of their choice ahead of the legislature's Monsoon Session beginning August 13.

Shivakumar is expected to submit a proposed list of portfolios to the top brass, with the allocation likely to be finalised on Monday. The negotiations have become contentious, particularly over key departments assigned to ministers who have been unhappy with them.

Food and civil supplies minister KH Munivappa, who belongs to the Dalit Left community, is among those seeking a change. He is insisting on the social welfare department, a portfolio that has traditionally seen competing claims from the Dalit Left and Dalit Right groups, said a leader in the know of the development.

The party had taken two months to expand the ministry after 13 Ministers were sworn in alongside Shivakumar on June 3. Shivakumar's Delhi visit also comes amid efforts to manage discontent among senior legislators who were left out of the Cabinet. Congress general secretary in charge of Karnataka Randeep

CM IS EXPECTED TO SUBMIT A PROPOSED LIST OF PORTFOLIOS TO THE TOP BRASS, WITH THE ALLOCATION LIKELY TO BE FINALISED ON MONDAY

Singh Surjewala has held discussions with several such legislators in recent days.

There has been speculation that some of the newly inducted ministers could be removed to make room for senior leaders. But several party leaders said such an arrangement would be difficult because there is little room left in the Cabinet.

The final composition of the ministry has continued to generate questions. Former minister KV Rajanna said on Sunday that three lists had been prepared before the ministers were sworn in, pointing to confusion during the final stages of the exercise.

Urban development minister Yathindra Siddaramaiah, however, said his father and former chief minister Siddaramaiah was not unhappy.

One Cabinet position remains vacant and is expected to go to a woman.

"The party is looking for a consensus candidate, with a

woman minister likely to be inducted in the coming days," said another senior leader.

M.L.C. AV Gayatri Shanthegowda, whose name appeared in the first list, was not inducted after Siddaramaiah opposed her candidature.

The Cabinet's composition has also triggered dissatisfaction among Brahmin community organisations, that said that no Brahmin MLA has received a ministerial position in the current government. According to community leaders, every government over the past three decades had included at least one Brahmin minister. Dinesh Gundu Rao has held a Cabinet position in the previous Siddaramaiah government.

The All Karnataka Brahmin Maha Sabha has held a protest over the lack of representation. Its president S. Raghunath, leader Ashok Hornali and others have demanded that the government address the issue.

"The Congress government talks about 'social justice' that brings all communities together. However, the Brahmin community, which has been making important contributions administratively and culturally, has been completely ignored. If the government does not take a suitable decision on our representation in the coming days, the community will have to take a suitable political stand in the next elections," Raghunath said.

The community is also discussing further measures, including non-cooperation with the government and Congress-organised religious programmes.

Raghunath said a joint meeting of state-level religious leaders and representatives of community organisations would be convened soon.

The BJP and JD(S) are preparing to take up the issue politically. Brahmin leaders have said the absence of representation could affect Congress support among sections of the community in Bengaluru, coastal areas, Malnad and Old Mysuru.

Meanwhile, BJP on Sunday urged chief minister D.K. Shivakumar to drop minister B. Nagendra from the Cabinet over allegations of financial irregularities involving crores of rupees at a state-run corporation. The opposition party warned that it would protest the issue both inside and outside the legislature. The monsoon session of the Karnataka legislature begins on August 13.

Nagendra, who resigned from the previous Siddaramaiah-led Cabinet following allegations of embezzlement of funds from the Karnataka Mahashila Valmiki Scheduled Tribes Development Corporation, was inducted into the D.K. Shivakumar-led Ministry on August 3. He said the BJP condemned the decision to make a minister of a person who had "looted" money meant for the development of children.

NCW CHIEF CALLS FOR TIME-BOUND TRIALS IN CRIMES AGAINST WOMEN

Press Trust of India
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: National Commission for Women chairperson Vijaya Raghavakar on Sunday called for time-bound trials in heinous crimes against women and urged courts to ensure that victims and their families do not have to repeatedly approach the judiciary for relief already granted. Speaking at the valedictory ceremony of the south zone regional conference on "Justice for Women" here, she highlighted the 2022 Shradha Walker murder case, describing it as a "painful example" of how justice can be delayed.

Recalling the brutal murder of the young woman, she said her body was cut into pieces, kept in a refrigerator, and later thrown on various streets of Delhi.

"The victim's father died in February last year while waiting for justice. Her grandmother has also passed away," the NCW chairperson said.

"Now, the citizen of the country is asking whether a sociology exam or dental check-up of the accused, who did a cold-blooded, brutal murder, is so important that justice cannot be delivered for four years. We need to be sensitive in such cases, where the victim and her family are suffering. Providing justice is important, but ensuring the trust in the eyes of citizens, that justice is being delivered is more important," Raghavakar said. Emphasising that the judiciary is the last resort for anyone, and that it is even more difficult for many women, she said the justice process must make survivors feel supported, and protected, not intimidated.

BJP, JD(S) join hands against Bidadi township

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: The proposed Bidadi Township is set to become a major flashpoint in Karnataka's Monsoon Session, with the BJP and JD(S) on Sunday launching a joint march against the project even as the state government has appointed a former High Court chief justice-led panel to review it.

Union minister HD Kumaraswamy and leader of Opposition R Ashoka joined JD(S) youth wing president Nikhil Kumaraswamy in flagging off the padayatra from Bengaluru on Sunday.

The march is scheduled to reach Bengaluru on Tuesday, when the parties plan a protest at Freedom Park.

The government's four-member committee, headed by retired High Court judge Justice Guhanath Narendran, has been given 30 days to examine the proposed township, also called the Greater Bengaluru Integrated Suburb project. Its members are retired chief secretary SV Ranganath, retired additional chief secretary SR Umashankar and retired IAS officer Prasanna Kumar. The panel will assess the project from legal, humanitarian and social perspectives before submitting its recommendations. The BJP and JD(S) are preparing to take up the project during the Assembly session beginning August 13. The march is the first major joint protest by the two parties, with the JD(S) leading the mobilisation and the BJP preparing to raise the issue in the legislature.

Kumaraswamy used the launch to revive a Congress fact finding report from 2006, prepared by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

K'taka HC gets 6 new judges

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: Chief minister DK Shivakumar, and chief justice of the Karnataka high court Vibhu Bakhru on Sunday inaugurated the new judges of the Karnataka high court during the swearing-in ceremony at Raj Bhavan, in Bengaluru on Sunday. The newly appointed additional judges are Raghavendra Seetharam Shriniva, Hema Kulkarni, Subrahmanya Rangarao, Tadagadagi Prakash Vivekananda, Baksheshwara Pramod and Hombergowda Shantini Bhushan.



Governor Thawar Chaud Gehlot, chief minister DK Shivakumar, and chief justice of the Karnataka high court Vibhu Bakhru with six newly sworn-in additional judges of the Karnataka high court during the swearing-in ceremony at Raj Bhavan, in Bengaluru on Sunday. The newly appointed additional judges are Raghavendra Seetharam Shriniva, Hema Kulkarni, Subrahmanya Rangarao, Tadagadagi Prakash Vivekananda, Baksheshwara Pramod and Hombergowda Shantini Bhushan.

Finance firm employee on solo trek at Shivagange goes missing

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A 31-year-old man who set out alone for a morning trek at Shivagange in Nelamangala taluk on Friday has been missing since, with police searching the hill and surrounding areas after CCTV footage showed him climbing the hill but offered no clues about where he went next, police said.

Advait Upadhyay, a finance firm employee in Whitefield and a resident of Begur, had travelled to Shivagange after his trekking plans.

Police said he reached the hill at about 6.30 am and left his rented motorcycle at the foothills before proceeding uphill. A missing person case was registered at Kadugodi police station after a complaint from his family.

His mobile phone has

Finance firm employee on solo trek at Shivagange goes missing

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A 31-year-old man who set out alone for a morning trek at Shivagange in Nelamangala taluk on Friday has been missing since, with police searching the hill and surrounding areas after CCTV footage showed him climbing the hill but offered no clues about where he went next, police said.

Advait Upadhyay, a finance firm employee in Whitefield and a resident of Begur, had travelled to Shivagange after his trekking plans.

Police said he reached the hill at about 6.30 am and left his rented motorcycle at the foothills before proceeding uphill. A missing person case was registered at Kadugodi police station after a complaint from his family.

His mobile phone has

Finance firm employee on solo trek at Shivagange goes missing

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A 31-year-old man who set out alone for a morning trek at Shivagange in Nelamangala taluk on Friday has been missing since, with police searching the hill and surrounding areas after CCTV footage showed him climbing the hill but offered no clues about where he went next, police said.

Advait Upadhyay, a finance firm employee in Whitefield and a resident of Begur, had travelled to Shivagange after his trekking plans.

Police said he reached the hill at about 6.30 am and left his rented motorcycle at the foothills before proceeding uphill. A missing person case was registered at Kadugodi police station after a complaint from his family.

His mobile phone has

Finance firm employee on solo trek at Shivagange goes missing

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A 31-year-old man who set out alone for a morning trek at Shivagange in Nelamangala taluk on Friday has been missing since, with police searching the hill and surrounding areas after CCTV footage showed him climbing the hill but offered no clues about where he went next, police said.

Advait Upadhyay, a finance firm employee in Whitefield and a resident of Begur, had travelled to Shivagange after his trekking plans.

Police said he reached the hill at about 6.30 am and left his rented motorcycle at the foothills before proceeding uphill. A missing person case was registered at Kadugodi police station after a complaint from his family.

His mobile phone has

Finance firm employee on solo trek at Shivagange goes missing

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

BENGALURU: A 31-year-old man who set out alone for a morning trek at Shivagange in Nelamangala taluk on Friday has been missing since, with police searching the hill and surrounding areas after CCTV footage showed him climbing the hill but offered no clues about where he went next, police said.

Advait Upadhyay, a finance firm employee in Whitefield and a resident of Begur, had travelled to Shivagange after his trekking plans.

Police said he reached the hill at about 6.30 am and left his rented motorcycle at the foothills before proceeding uphill. A missing person case was registered at Kadugodi police station after a complaint from his family.

His mobile phone has



Union minister HD Kumaraswamy with LoP in Legislative Assembly R Ashoka at a march in Bidadi on Sunday.

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48,000 areca nut trees and 13,000 neem trees. "In addition, the report says that the land is very fertile, as farmers are growing ragi in 1,130 acres, paddy in 714 acres, sugarcane in 414 acres, vegetables in 200 acres, and silk in 661 acres," Kumaraswamy said. Ashoka said the township was against the interests of farmers. He also alleged that the government appointed committee would eventually submit a report supporting the project and described its members as "payment" placements.

Shivakumar rejected the political challenge and said the opposition could raise the issue in the Assembly. "Nobody can hide the truth when it comes to the

paraded by a committee headed by Kadugudi Thimmappa. Shivakumar was a member of that committee. Kumaraswamy said the report had opposed the project and detailed the scale of agricultural land and properties that would be affected.

According to the figures cited by Kumaraswamy, the proposed acquisition area contains 3,000 houses, 48

Chidambaram slams T party for skipping delimitation meet

S Vijay Karthik
letters@hindustantimes.com

CHENNAI: Senior Congress leader and former Union home minister P Chidambaram on Sunday said Tamil Nadu lost an opportunity to announce to the world that there is a consensus regarding delimitation, referring to the absence of the opposition parties in the meeting of state MPs called by chief minister C Joseph Vijay.

Various parties including the Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK), All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), boycotted the meeting called by the ruling Tamil Nadu Vetri Kazhagam (TVK) on Saturday, dismissing it as "unnecessary". The meeting explored the possibilities of delimitation's impact on Tamil Nadu as the Centre might conduct a special session in the Parliament on delimitation.

Chidambaram said in a social media post on Sunday. Claiming that unity among political parties prevailed on delimitation in April this year, he said, "People must ask the question why the unity in April shattered in August". Every party must clearly state its stance on the Delimitation bill, he added.

In April, former Tamil Nadu chief minister MK Stalin brand a copy of the delimitation Bill and described it as a "black law" that would make Tamil people refugees on their own land. Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president Manickam

P CHIDAMBARAM SENIOR CONG LEADER

It saddened me that the DMK, AIADMK, PMK, DMDK did not participate in the meeting of the Tamil Nadu MPs convened by the chief minister



Chidambaram said in a social media post on Sunday.

Claiming that unity among political parties prevailed on delimitation in April this year, he said, "People must ask the question why the unity in April shattered in August". Every party must clearly state its stance on the Delimitation bill, he added.

In April, former Tamil Nadu chief minister MK Stalin brand a copy of the delimitation Bill and described it as a "black law" that would make Tamil people refugees on their own land.

Tamil Nadu Congress Committee president Manickam

Tamir said those who place their politics above Tamil Nadu's interest did not chose to attend and those who put the state first and politics second, attended the all-party meeting called by the chief minister.

Terming that the meeting was not about "party politics", he said it was about Tamil Nadu's rights, interests and future. "The people of Tamil Nadu are watching, and they will remember who stood with Tamil Nadu when it was in charge, first I will be in charge, first I will be in charge, first I will be in charge," he said.

Meanwhile, the AIADMK national spokesperson Koval Sathyan commenting about the TVK government holding the

meeting with Tamil Nadu MPs said, "The actions of TVK reflect political immaturity and theatrics, nothing else. There is an organisational structure and we have a general secretary in place. Whatever happens, it happens through him. Reaching out directly to the MPs is not the norm."

He asked whether the TVK would agree if any other party or any other person reached out to TVK's office bearers directly with the order of high command. "This is political immaturity and misplaced priorities," he said.

On the reasons why the DMK skipped the meeting, the party's national spokesperson Saravanan Annadurai said, "The DMK's stance is that delimitation should not be conducted."

Elaborating, Annadurai said, "In 2025, during DMK rule, an all-party meeting was convened and resolutions were passed. The first recommendation was when delimitation came in 2001, it was frozen for 25 years and pushed to 2026; now, freeze it for another 25 years from 2026."

When asked whether the DMK has not yet balanced, and the population in Northern states remains higher — that is one demand."

"Tamil Nadu should not face any impact, and the current political weightage must not be diluted. If we look at it now, there are 39 constituencies. Out of 534 constituencies, 39 represents 7.2%. Whether you increase or decrease the total count or not, this 7.2% share must not decrease. And that is the DMK's stance," he added.

However, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) rejected allegations that the delimitation exercise is a "conspiracy against Tamil Nadu".

The party's spokesperson Narayanan Thirupathi said, "It is a constitutional process applicable to the entire country. Article 82 and 170 of the Constitution mandate periodic readjustment of seats on the basis of population to uphold the fundamental democratic principle of 'one person, one vote, one value.' It is not a Tamil Nadu specific exercise," he said.

Stressing that the people of Tamil Nadu deserve responsible leadership that understands the Constitution, Thirupathi said, "The BJP stands firmly for fair, transparent and constitutionally mandated delimitation for the whole of India — not selective exemptions based on political convenience."

'VANDE MATARAM' DAYS AFTER CHIEF SECY ORDER ON 'FULL VERSION'

Only first 2 stanzas to be sung in Kerala: Minister

Vishnu Varma
letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala health minister K Muraliedharan on Sunday said that only the first two stanzas of the national song 'Vande Mataram' will be sung at government events. The clarification came days after a circular issued by the chief secretary asked for all physical celebrations during the full rendition of the song suspended a row in the state.

The August 6 order issued by chief secretary Bishwanath Sinha had echoed the Union minister's circular regarding the observance of the 'Har Ghar Tiranga' campaign across the country from August 9 to 17. The order stated that all physical celebrations during the full rendition of the song shall be suspended. The directive regarding the full rendition of the song sparked a controversy in Kerala where the UDF and LDF coalitions have argued that some of the later stanzas of the song have



K Muraliedharan

references to Hindu deities and therefore do not appeal to the country's pluralistic ideals. Muraliedharan said that while the chief secretary has the authority to issue orders, the Union government's directives regarding the rendition of 'Vande Mataram', only the first two stanzas of the song will be sung at government events.

"In the past, only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram are sung at government events in Kerala. We will stick to the same rule. Kerala will not follow the Union government's directives (on full rendition)," he told reporters.

He said that the swearing-in ceremony of the UDF government in May adhered to the full rendition of the song because the

Governor was in attendance. "Since the Governor was present, the central protocol was followed. But at state government functions, we can our own protocol," he said.

The chief secretary's order sparked a surprise among government officials as an earlier circular by the general administration department on August 4 did not mention the recital of the song as part of events leading up to Independence Day.

In February, the Centre had mandated that Vande Mataram be played or sung in full at all government events. The leader of the Opposition Pinarayi Vijayan alleged that the chief secretary's order points to the surrender of the UDF government to the RSS ideology. "The Constituent Assembly and leaders like Jawaharlal Nehru have been of the opinion that only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram need to be sung. At the UDF government's swearing-in, the song was rendered in full. Despite so much criticism against it, the government has issued such an order. It shows that the state government has surrendered fully to the RSS agenda," he said.

T Mohandas detained over remarks on Delhi protestors

Vishnu Varma
letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Right-wing commentator T Mohandas was taken into police custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, an officer said.

Mohandas was taken into custody from his residence in Kochi on Sunday, days after being charged for making provocative comments in a video about the BJP-led protests at Jantar Mantar

More likely to table 2 bills today

Pallavi Singhal

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Union home minister Amit Shah is scheduled to introduce two bills — one seeking to rename Kerala as Keralam and another expanding the financing powers of the National Co-operative Development Corporation (NCDC) — in the Lok Sabha on Monday, amid a logjam in both Houses of Parliament. With just four days left in the ongoing monsoon session, the Opposition parties are seeking a statement from the home minister over the use of force against protesting students on July 20.

The Kerala (Alteration of Name) Bill, 2026 seeks to amend the First Schedule of the Constitution to change the name of Kerala to "Keralam". The proposal follows a resolution passed by the Kerala assembly seeking the name change. The Union Cabinet has already approved the proposal.

The second bill, the National Co-operative Development Corporation (Amendment) Bill, 2026, seeks to expand the mandate of the NCDC. Instead of largely financing programmes through cooperative societies, according to the draft bill, the corporation will also be able to fund a wider range of organisations involved in "co-operative development".

The proposed changes mean the government argues that the cooperative sector has "expanded and diversified considerably" over the years. According to the state's "objects and reasons" accompanying the bill, statutory bodies, state government agencies and other specialised organisations now provide infrastructure,



Amit Shah

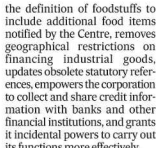
technology, processing, marketing and financial services to cooperatives. As many of these organisations are not themselves registered as cooperative societies, the NCDC cannot finance them directly under existing law. The resulting "procedural delays and limited uptake" as proposals have to be routed through state governments or cooperative societies.

To address this, the bill allows the corporation to extend loans and grants directly not only to cooperative societies but also to any entity engaged in co-operative development, and, with the Centre's approval, invest in the share capital of such entities.

The broader wording has prompted questions over which organisations could qualify for funding. L. Viswanathan, senior partner at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas, said the provision should not be interpreted as opening the door to all entities.

"The key is that these entities must be engaged in co-operative development," he said, adding that the board would determine eligibility based on the purpose and mandate of the organisation.

Besides widening the funding net, the bill also seeks to expand



Jasveer Gandhi

the definition of foodstuffs to include additional food items notified by the Centre, removes geographical restrictions on financing industrial goods, updates obsolete statutory references, empowers the corporation to collect and share credit information with banks and other financial institutions, and grants it incidental powers to carry out its functions more effectively.

The bill also authorises the NCDC to acquire equity in entities engaged in cooperative development, subject to prior approval of the Centre. On concerns over safeguards, Viswanathan said the law itself places limits on how funds can be used. "The end use of the funds is specified in the law. The law provides for audits and reports to be filed by NCDC. Anything beyond that will be ultra vires," he said, adding that any equity investment would also be subject to greater checks and balances on the end use and activities.

On Sunday, the Opposition Congress intensified its demand for a statement from Shah on police excesses during the July 20 march to Parliament. Drawing a parallel with the Opposition's demand for a response from Shah following the December 13, 2023 Parliament security breach incident, Congress leader Jairam Ramesh said: "History should not be repeated."

The entire opposition reportedly demanded that the Union Home Minister make a statement on this (Parliament breach) incident, but no statement came from him. They remained silent even then, just as they are now silent on the brutality inflicted by the Delhi Police on the youth who were protesting last month," he said on X.

Tribunal bill set to be introduced in LS today

Jasveer Gandhi

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Union government is likely to table The Tribunal Reforms Bill, 2026, which proposes creation of long-pending National Tribunals Commission (NTC) to oversee the selection process for filling up the vacancies in various tribunals across the country, in the Lok Sabha on Monday, according to the List of Business, on the Lok Sabha's website.

The National Tribunals Commission, according to the draft bill, will also review the performance of chairperson and members of tribunals, submit annual reports to the Centre, and maintain a National Tribunals Grid.

Congress lawmaker Jairam Ramesh said his party was in support of the bill, which is likely to chart "a new future" for 16 semi-judicial tribunals across the country, including the National Green Tribunal, set up in 2010.

In the bill, Ramesh said, came following directions of the Supreme Court last year and it should rectify key changes the Centre had attempted through a much different Tribunal Reforms Act, 2021.

This bill seeks to implement the Supreme Court's directions in the landmark Madras Bar Association judgment of November 19, 2025, that had

struck down key provisions of the Tribunals Reforms Act, 2021 and called for an independent National Tribunals Commission for appointments. Since the very existence of an independent NGT was at stake, I had also joined the challenge to the 2021 Act in the Supreme Court," Ramesh said in a post on X.

In its November 19, 2025 order, the top court struck down key provisions of the Tribunals Reforms Act, 2021 for violating judicial independence and the separation of powers. Ramesh was among the petitioners challenging the constitutional validity of the law.

Among the changes, top court invalidated the 2021 law's 50-year age limit requirement for appointment, which excluded younger yet qualified advocates, restored a five-year tenure for members by striking down shortened four-year tenure as envisaged in the legislation, and also struck down a rule requiring the selection committee to propose two nominees per vacancy by reinstating a single-name recommendation process to limit executive discretion.

The draft bill, which HT has seen, states the National Tribunals Commission will have its headquarters in Delhi and consist of a chairperson and four members, of whom, two will be judicial members and two technical members.

{ JHARKHAND PROTESTS } ASSEMBLY MARCH TODAY

Deadlock continues, Sore assesses justice

Raj Kumar

letters@hindustantimes.com

RANCHI: The high-stakes standoff between the Jharkhand government and protesting student groups remains firmly deadlocked despite intense rounds of negotiations at the State Guest House in Morabadi, even as chief minister Hemant Soren said that his government is handling the situation with the utmost sensitivity and seriousness.

While the government claims to have conceded nearly all major student demands, student unions refused to back down without the complete cancellation of the Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission (JSSC) Combined Graduate Level (CGL) examination.

Minister Sudhya Kumar Sonu said authorities acted in good faith to resolve the crisis. "The government has accepted 98% of the students' demands to ensure a fair academic and recruitment environment," Sonu said.

The minister emphasised that the core demand regarding the CGL exam falls outside executive jurisdiction. "The state government does not have the authority to cancel the CGL examination. It



Protesters receive medical attention during hunger strike in Ranchi on Saturday.

was conducted following specific directives from both the High Court and the Supreme Court. Consequently, the government cannot unilaterally cancel the exam, nor can we legally overturn the appointments of candidates who have already been selected through this established process."

He said the government is fully prepared to constitute an independent inquiry committee, headed by a retired judge, to thoroughly investigate all alleged irregularities in the CGL process.

Despite the assurances, student leaders remain completely unsatisfied. The agitating students sought support from political parties and common people for their ongoing peaceful democratic protest and proposed 'Vidhan Sabha

March' on Monday. Addressing a press conference in Ranchi, the demonstrators said they would not allow anti-student elements to disrupt their democratic agitation. "The Jharkhand government is spreading lies that it fulfilled 98% of our demands. It cancelled only 3 of 13 exams sought by us," a student leader alleged, as reported by news agency PTI.

The Jharkhand Police imposed prohibitory orders around the assembly premises and made elaborate security arrangements across the city in view of the march called by students.

At an event, CM Soren promised that the state would ensure complete justice and enforce the strictest punishments against anyone found guilty of compromising the examination process. "Our administration remains deeply committed to safeguarding the future of the youth," he said.

Meanwhile, three Jharkhand Public Service Commission members resigned on Sunday after CGL resumed under other allied irregularities governor Santosh Kumar Gangwar accepted the resignation of Ajeeta Bhattacharya, Anima Hansda and Jamal Ahmad, said the Lok Sabha.

Joshi chairs meet on NTA-related matters

Sanjay Maurya

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Union Minister Pralhad Joshi, who has secured given the additional portfolio of education ministry, on Sunday held his first meeting with officials on "matters concerning the National Testing Agency (NTA) and discussed steps for stronger mechanism, streamlining processes, and better student support."

Recently the testing body has faced criticism over the alleged NEET-UG exam 2026 paper leak in May and is currently facing students' complaints about over a month delays in releasing official answer keys for UGC-NEET June 2026 session.

The meeting was held in the office of minister of consumer affairs, food and public distribution, new and renewable energy.

"Convened a meeting with the Secretary and senior officials of the NTA on matters concerning the National Testing Agency (NTA). Deliberated on key matters requiring attention and steps ahead to further strengthen institutional mechanisms, streamline processes and ensure greater responsiveness to students," Joshi said on X.

"Our focus remains on building a robust, transparent and credible examination ecosystem that serves the aspirations of every student," he said.

Pralhad Joshi, who serves as minister of consumer affairs, food and public distribution; and



Vishnu Varma

letters@hindustantimes.com

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala health minister K Muralidharan on Sunday said that only first two stanzas of the national song "Vande Mataram" will be sung at government events. The clarification comes days after a circular issued by chief secretary Bishwanath Sinha asking for the full rendition of the song sparked a row in the state.

The August 6 order issued by the minister regarding the clarification issued by chief secretary Bishwanath Sinha asking for the full rendition of the song sparked a row in the state.

The order stated that all physical examinations during the period "shall combine the collective singing of 'Vande Mataram' with the hoisting/display of the National Flag." It also stated that "the collection of the Union government" for recitation of Vande Mataram be followed in full.

Muralidharan said while the chief secretary may have organically relayed the Centre's directives regarding the rendition of "Vande Mataram," only the first two stanzas will be sung at government events.

"In the past, only the first two stanzas of Vande Mataram were sung at government events in Kerala. We will stick to the same rule," he said.

According to Mevani, sustained agitation that followed the decision by the Union to possess of nearly 2,000 acres of land that had long remained under the control of dominant caste families in the area. The land was to be allotted to poor people at a cost of about 10,000 acres out to Dalits that are still not in their physical possession. If people are forced to raise this issue, but the government must provide alternatives through land and jobs," Mevani said he has repeatedly raised the issue of the assurances made to the Union victims during successive Budget sessions of the Gujarat Assembly since becoming an MLA in 2017.

For the last eight years I have been raising this issue, but there is no answer," he said.

For the Sarvaiyas, however, politics has always come after survival. Until now, the family depends on selling milk from the few cows and buffaloes it owns. The income barely sustains the household of seven. Vashrambhai said the burden has grown heavier as his eight-year-old daughter undergoes treatment for thalassemia. "There was no alternative livelihood waiting for us. We simply decided we would rather struggle than go back."

IN PUDUCHERRY, SHAH PRESENTS PREZ'S COLOUR TO UT POLICE

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

PUDUCHERRY: Union home minister Amit Shah presented the President's Colour to Puducherry Police on Sunday and praised the force for its commitment and dedication in ensuring the country's internal security.

In his address, the home minister said, "Today, presenting the prestigious President's Colour flag to the Puducherry Police department is a truly wonderful moment. This honour and distinction have been conferred upon only very few states in the country, making it as a matter of immense pride."

The President's Colour is the highest honour given to a military unit or police force of a state or Union territory. Past recipients of the honour include the Indian Navy, Indian Coast Guard and various state police departments.

President Droupadi Murmu had announced on May 8 the conferment of the honour on Puducherry police in recognition of its "exceptional service, discipline and distinguished achievements".

Shoes, mud thrown at Mamata during visit to worker's home

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee was allegedly attacked by a mob that hurled shoes, mud and stones at her car on Sunday during her visit to Halishahar, a slum in the city. The 24 Parliament District to meet the family of a Trinamool Congress (TMC) worker who died in police custody the previous day, people familiar with the matter said, adding that the TMC chairperson was unhurt in the incident, as she did not step out of the vehicle.

The agitation, who carried no party flag and claimed to be local residents, said they were angry because Mamata Banerjee had never visited the area while in power. They shouted slogans like "go back" and "thief at heart". The local police did not make a statement, but chief minister Suvashree Chatterjee, who is also in charge of the home department, defended the force during a visit to North 24 Parganas.

"I saw the incident (in videos). TMC police officers did their job and ensured her safety. The victim's family is saying they nei-



Former West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee speaks to the media following the attack on her vehicle in Barrapore on Sunday.

ther invited her to their home nor asked for her interference. They said they are happy with her visit to Halishahar. The way they (TMC leaders) do, the former minister chose a holiday to go there and make some noise," Adhikari said.

Meanwhile, Mamata Banerjee accused the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) of planning the attack. "We would have died if any of the stones had hit us. This was planned by the BJP as a mass outrage. Our party workers were not involved in the incident but we condemn such gross misconduct," Bhattacharya said.

Union development minister Agnimitra Paul echoed Bhattacharya's sentiment.

workers to hurl shoes and mud at a former chief minister's car. "This was a conspiracy to murder Mamata Banerjee," Kalyan Banerjee said.

BJP state president Samik Bhattacharya denied the involvement of his party workers. "The way they (TMC leaders) are saying there was an attempt to kill a chief minister suggests they have not gotten over the hangover of power. This was a mass outrage. Our party workers were not involved in the incident but we condemn such gross misconduct," Bhattacharya said.

Union development minister Agnimitra Paul echoed Bhattacharya's sentiment.

HAR GHAR TIRANGA DRIVE TO DEEPEN SENSE OF NATIONAL UNITY, SAYS BJP

Press Trust of India

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) on Sunday appealed to people to join the "Har Ghar Tiranga" campaign in large numbers by hoisting the national flag at their homes, establishments and workplaces, saying the initiative will strengthen the spirit of patriotism and national unity.

In separate posts on X, BJP leaders urged people to participate in the campaign being held from August 9 to 17 and make the tricolour a part of every home and every heart.

BJP president Nitin Nabin said the tricolour is a symbol of India's pride, unity and the sacrifices made for freedom, inspiring every Indian to give their best in the service of the nation. "The tricolour is a symbol of our pride, unity and the sacrifices made for freedom, inspiring every Indian to give their best in the service of the nation."

"Under the esteemed leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi ji, the Har Ghar Tiranga campaign is becoming a powerful medium to spread the spirit of patriotism to every individual," Nabin said. "Let us all join this campaign with enthusiasm and ensure our participation in the resolve to build a developed India," he said.

Strong def order books must translate into faster execution: Panel

Rahul Singh

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The robust order books of defence, public sector undertakings must translate into timely execution of projects, adherence to delivery schedules, says a further expansion of manufacturing capabilities, a parliamentary panel has told the defence ministry.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Defence made the observation in its latest report after reviewing the performance and order books of nine DPSUs, including Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) and Bharat Electronics Limited (BEL), with combined orders worth ₹4,50,452 crore as on March 31, 2026.

The panel also asked the ministry to share details and efforts of other DPSUs' entry into foreign markets in its action taken statement. The panel has also asked the department to periodically review the effectiveness of the ease of doing business (EoB) reforms of all DPSUs, identify procedural bottlenecks, and take steps to help them boost defence exports. All DPSUs, it should "also closely monitor the implementation of contracts so that the operational and financial performance of the defence ministry's defence preparedness and the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat."

The panel also asked the ministry to share details and efforts of other DPSUs' entry into foreign markets in its action taken statement. The panel has also asked the department to periodically review the effectiveness of the ease of doing business (EoB) reforms of all DPSUs, identify procedural bottlenecks, and take steps to help them boost defence exports. All DPSUs, it should "also closely monitor the implementation of contracts so that the operational and financial performance of the defence ministry's defence preparedness and the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat."

₹74,000 crore. Garden Reach Shipbuilders & Engineers Ltd at ₹31,700 crore, Bharat Dynamics Ltd at ₹24,048 crore and Mazda Shipbuilding Industries Ltd (MDIL) at ₹20,582 crore.

The ministry told that MDIL last year acquired a controlling stake in Sri Lanka's largest state-owned shipbuilding company, Colombo Dockyard PLC, in a deal valued at ₹452 crore. Colombo Dockyard has over five decades of experience in shipbuilding, ship repair, and heavy engineering.

The committee held the shipyard's foray into the global market, and asked the ministry to share details and efforts of other DPSUs' entry into foreign markets in its action taken statement. The panel has also asked the department to periodically review the effectiveness of the ease of doing business (EoB) reforms of all DPSUs, identify procedural bottlenecks, and take steps to help them boost defence exports. All DPSUs, it should "also closely monitor the implementation of contracts so that the operational and financial performance of the defence ministry's defence preparedness and the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat."

The panel also asked the ministry to share details and efforts of other DPSUs' entry into foreign markets in its action taken statement. The panel has also asked the department to periodically review the effectiveness of the ease of doing business (EoB) reforms of all DPSUs, identify procedural bottlenecks, and take steps to help them boost defence exports. All DPSUs, it should "also closely monitor the implementation of contracts so that the operational and financial performance of the defence ministry's defence preparedness and the vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat."

INDIA CROSSES 300 GW IN NON-FOSSIL FUEL CAPACITY

Jasveer Gandhi

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India has crossed 300 GW (gigawatt) of installed non-fossil electricity capacity, the Centre said on Sunday, adding that this was yet another key milestone in the country's green energy transition. This is over 60% of the 500 GW capacity target the government has set to be achieved by 2030. Data shared by the ministry of new and renewable (MNRE) showed as on July 31, 2026, India's total non-fossil electricity capacity stood at 300.50 GW, comprising 164.59 GW from solar power, 58.14 GW of wind power, 57.24 GW of large and small hydropower, 11.75 GW of bio-power and 8.78 GW through nuclear power.

The share of non-fossil fuel electricity capacity in the country's total electricity generation capacity (which is around 592 GW at present), has reached over 54%. Backed through the key policy enablers provided by the government, this transformation, this monumental achievement highlights India's rapid progress towards building an Atmanirbhar energy ecosystem and the country's commitment to achieving net-zero by 2070, the central ministry said in a statement on Sunday.

The rapid uptake has particularly been strong in the solar sector.

Una flogging 10 years on: Fight for justice continues for Sarvaiya family

Maulik Pathak

letters@hindustantimes.com

AHMEDABAD: Every morning, the Sarvaiya household in Mota Samadhiya village of Gai Somnath district begins the day with a ritual to the two cows and two buffaloes before milk is supplied to a local dairy. The income barely supports the family's seven members. It is a livelihood they chose after giving up lifting and skinning dead cattle, work generations of Dalits were expected to perform because of caste.

On July 11, 2016, brothers Vashrambhai and Ramesh Sarvaiya, along with their cousins Ashok and Bechar Sarvaiya, were tied to a vehicle, stripped to the waist and flogged by self-styled cow vigilantes after they were accused of slaughtering a cow near their village. Videos of the assault spread across the country, triggering outrage, sparking one of Gujarat's biggest Dalit student-led protests. The conversation around caste discrimination and cow vigilantism.

Ten years later, the family's struggle has shifted from the courtroom to the streets. The fight is rebuilding its life. It continues to fight a legal battle despite a trial court verdict, waits for what it hopes are promises of rehabilitation made after the assault to be fulfilled and survives on a modest



The four members of Sarvaiya family were tied to a vehicle and assaulted by cow vigilantes on July 11, 2016.

income from selling milk to a local dairy. "We understood Bababhai Ambedkar only after Una," said Vashrambhai, now 33. "We realised we should not continue such work imposed on us only because of our caste. We decided that no matter how difficult life became, we would never again lift or skin dead animals."

Within days after the assault on July 11, 2016, thousands of Dalits marched on the streets, blocked highways and declared they would no longer remove the carcasses of dead cattle. The protests culminated in the Dalit Asmita Yatra, led by activist Jignesh Mevani from Ahmedabad. Ahmedabad during the movement and pledged they would never again lift dead animals."

For Mevani, who later entered the Gujarat Assembly, the movement remains one of the defining moments in Gujarat's Dalit politics. "The practice of lifting dead animals was deeply entrenched. It was never going to disappear in a few years," Mevani said. "More than 15,000 Dalits gathered at ChandiKheda. Ahmedabad during the movement and pledged they would never again lift dead animals."

[PHUKET-DELHI FLIGHT TURBULENCE]

AAIB initiates probe, captain's dope test results awaited: Govt

HT Correspondent
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The civil aviation ministry on Sunday said the Air Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) has begun investigating the turbulence-related incident involving an Air India flight from Phuket to Delhi on August 4.

The occurrence has been classified as a serious incident and is under investigation by the Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB), the ministry said in a statement. The ministry had earlier said the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA) was investigating the matter.

The government also said a psychoactive substance screening test of the pilot in command (PIC) returned a result requiring confirmatory testing. "As part of the Standard Operating Procedures, both flight crew members underwent the prescribed psychoactive substance screening test. The screening test in respect of the PIC indicated a result requiring confirmatory testing. Samples have accordingly been sent to the designated laboratory, and the final report is awaited," the statement said.

The Air India A320 aircraft, VT-EXO, operating flight AI 2379



The aircraft suddenly dropped 300 feet, leading to injuries to a few passengers.

from Phuket to Delhi, experienced a sudden loss of altitude during cruise. The aircraft subsequently landed safely in Delhi. A few passengers and cabin crew members reported injuries during the incident. The aircraft was carrying 137 passengers.

Civil aviation minister Ram Mohan Naidu said on August 6 that two crew members who suffered spinal injuries remained admitted to Fortis Hospital.

"Pending investigation and completion of the prescribed process, both flight crew members have been taken off roster by the DGCA. Further action, as

appropriate, will be taken based on the outcome of the investigation and confirmatory test results," the government said.

An industry expert said, "The first test that takes around three hours, says 'non-negative' and not positive. Then it's sent for a more comprehensive and detailed test which takes around three days."

Earlier on Sunday, an Air India spokesperson said, "We are aware that a post-flight screening test was conducted on the pilots in accordance with applicable protocols. However, the results of the test have not been shared with Air India, and we are therefore not in a position to comment on any findings. We will continue to cooperate with the relevant authorities as required."

Srikant Jha, a US resident who was on board the flight, said, "My family and I found the pilot to be shabbily dressed when we saw him at the airport but that did not raise an alarm then. It was after the incident when he came out to speak to the passengers that most of us thought he was intoxicated because he walked differently and threatened us all to not shoot a video." Jha, who was on a family trip to Phuket, has complained on the Air Sewa portal and also written to the US embassy in India.

Private trainer aircraft veers off runway in Baramati, no casualty

Neha LM Tripathi and
Shrinivas Deshpande
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI/PUNE: A training aircraft veered off the runway at Maharashtra's Baramati airport on Sunday during a flying exercise, the civil aviation ministry said on Sunday, adding that nobody was injured in the incident.

This is the third aircraft accident at Baramati since Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) leader and former Maharashtra deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar's plane crash in January this year.

The Cessna 172 aircraft, bearing registration number VT-SEX, was operated by Academy of Carver Aviation—a Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA)-approved Flying Training Organisation (FTO). The incident took place at around 12.25pm after the aircraft taxied for scheduled training exercise at around 12.09pm.

The aircraft was being operated for a Circuit and Landing Emergencies (CLE) training exercise, the government said in a statement. It was under the command of Capt Chirag Shashikant Dofode, the flight instructor, along with trainee Abhijeet Jundre, the statement added.

During the course of the exercise, the aircraft was unable to stop within the paved runway surface



The Cessna 172 aircraft was being operated for a training exercise by Academy of Carver Aviation.

and "veered off the extended paved surface beyond the threshold of Runway 29 towards the right side, resulting in a runway excursion," the statement said.

Baramati acts like an aviation training hub, as it is home to FTOs Academy of Carver Aviation Pvt Ltd and Redbird Flight Training Academy for pilots' training. In January, a Learjet 45 operated by VSR Ventures crashed while attempting to land at Baramati, killing then deputy CM Ajit Pawar and four others.

On May 13, a trainer aircraft operated by the Redbird Flight Training Academy crashed near Gophavi village, close to the airstrip. The trainee pilot, who was the only person on board, escaped safely.

runway and continued beyond the threshold of runway 29."

The incident comes at a time when the Maharashtra government is finalising a ₹100-crore overhaul of the small, uncontrolled airstrip at Baramati.

It also comes months after two other aircraft accidents in the vicinity of the Baramati airstrip. In January, a Learjet 45 operated by VSR Ventures crashed while attempting to land at Baramati, killing then deputy CM Ajit Pawar and four others.

On May 13, a trainer aircraft operated by the Redbird Flight Training Academy crashed near Gophavi village, close to the airstrip. The trainee pilot, who was the only person on board, escaped safely.

Laser beam distracts pilot at Kolkata airport

KOLKATA: A Malaysia Airlines flight MH-184 from Kuala Lumpur carrying 159 passengers faced problem while approaching the Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose International Airport for landing as the pilot was distracted by a laser beam, airport officials said on Sunday.

The flight was scheduled to land at 11.20pm on Saturday, but when the aircraft was approximately eight nautical miles

from the runway, the pilot reportedly noticed a bright laser beam flashing towards the cockpit, the officials said.

The aircraft finally landed safely at around 11.25pm and all passengers and crew members were reported safe, they said. Following the incident, the airline informed the airport authorities. The authorities also lodged a complaint with the NSCB Airport Police Station.

Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.

HT FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

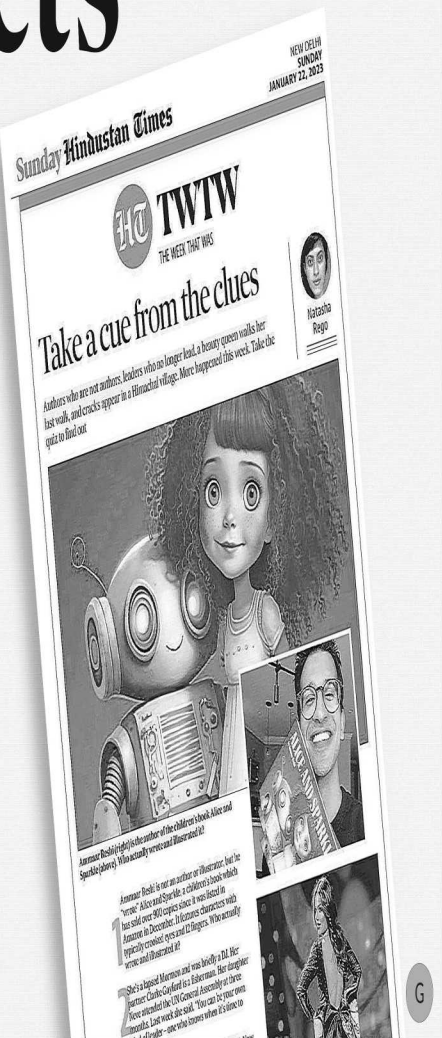
Have fun with facts on Sundays

Catch the latest column of

HT TWTW

THE WEEK THAT WAS

A quiz on the week's development.



CURIOSITY DESERVES A SUNDAY

Spend Sunday discovering something you didn't know you wanted to know. From culture and lifestyle to ideas that shift perspectives, HT WKND brings together stories that surprise, inspire and stay with you long after you've turned the page.



HT wknd
A PART OF YOUR EVERYDAY LIFE

READ EVERY SUNDAY



Vizag, Thane residents oppose large AI data centres, cite resource constraints

Soumya Chatterjee
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's ambition to become an artificial intelligence (AI) powerhouse is beginning to face the challenge of local resistance that has slowed data centre projects in parts of Europe and North America. In Thane and Visakhapatnam, residents have launched what are among the country's first organised protests against large data centres, arguing that the projects could put additional pressure on land, electricity and water.

The protests come as the Centre encourages investment in digital infrastructure. At the AI Summit in February, Prime Minister Narendra Modi urged technology companies to set up their data centres in India, pitching the country as a hub for AI infrastructure. Data centres were granted infrastructure status in 2022, while this year's Union Budget announced a tax holiday until 2047 for eligible foreign cloud service providers. Several states have also introduced policies and incentives to attract investment.

"Half of Thane is living on tanker water. Why have the data centres in a residential area and put all the citizens in trouble?" said Sadhana Pradhan, one of the residents leading the Wake Up Thane campaign. Residents are not opposed to technology or AI but to building one of the country's biggest data centres in a densely populated residential area without fully addressing its long-term impact on the neighbourhood.

In Thane, the data centre facing protests is Amazon's hyperscale facility, spread across about 53-58 acres at Balkum and Majiwada. The campaign began after residents learnt that data centres are classified as essential services, raising concerns that they could receive priority access to water and electricity during shortages. After scrutinising the project's approvals, the group sent Amazon and the Thane Municipal Corporation (TMC) a 22-point questionnaire. It asked whether mandatory public notices on environmental clearance had been issued, whether water and sewerage approvals had been obtained



Thane residents protest against Amazon's proposed data centre at Balkum and Majiwada.

before construction began, and how the project's water demand compared with subsequent commitments made by the civic body. They also sought details on thermal impact, emergency preparedness, inspection reports, power demand and compliance with environmental conditions.

The TMC said residents need not worry about drinking water being diverted. Deputy city engineer Dhole said the proposed Amazon facility would require 12 million litres a day (MLD) of treated sewage water. He said the corporation currently had sewage treatment capacity of about 300 MLD and supplied around 600 MLD of water across the city, with recycled wastewater being supplied for industrial use rather than as potable water.

However, residents are also concerned about heat generated by cooling systems, noise from equipment, pressure on the local power network and the cumulative impact of locating a massive data centre next to homes, schools and hospitals.

In its response, Amazon said its data centre development in Thane would not use water for cooling. "In fact, we do not currently use water for cooling in any of our data centres in India, and do not draw from the community's drinking or potable water for cooling purposes. The approved water supply permit for the Thane data centre is 0.01 MLD and is strictly for basic human needs, including restrooms and drinking water for

Amazon employees." It said the data centre would be built and operated in compliance with the Noise Pollution (Regulation and Control) Rules, 2000. "We are investing in advanced technology and engineering for energy-leading sound management, including sound-dampening building materials and insulation, strategic placement of equipment, and acoustic enclosures and mufflers where needed. The generators will not be a consistent use and will mostly run for brief midday tests to ensure they are ready and reliable when needed during rare emergencies."

The company added that heat from the servers would be released through cooling towers or air-handling systems that distribute it efficiently. The heat dissipates naturally into the atmosphere without affecting the air temperature in nearby communities, Amazon said.

Nearly 80 km away, a similar campaign is taking shape in Visakhapatnam, where several citizens are opposing a proposed Google-Adani hyperscale AI data centre complex. Planned as a 1-GW cluster split across three sites, the project would cover about 200 acres at Tarlavada, 120 acres around Adavavaram-Mudasara, and 160 acres at Ramnabli in Anakapalle district.

Activists say the project raises several of the concerns voiced in Thane, while also creating additional worries over land acquisition and environmental clearances.

Over 100 people took part in a sit-in against the project on July 19. Deeksha Vanguru, one of the protesters and a co-founder of the Coalition for AI Regulation, said, "We are concerned about the lack of public consultation and the unchecked, rapid expansion of infrastructure that is more extractive and has fewer socio-economic returns. We also want to know why a ₹22,000-crore tax holiday is being given for these projects."

According to the protesters, water for the projects would be sourced from the Polavaram project or through desalination, which they said would be unsustainable for a city that is already water-stressed. Vanguru also questioned whether the projects justified the public resources they would consume, saying government environmental clearances indicated that the three sites together would create about 1,700 permanent jobs.

Vanguru alleged environmental clearances had been fudged and raised concerns over the availability of land and water and power rather than investment incentives alone. It also called for better disclosure of sustainability data and careful site selection before projects are approved.

The report noted that data centres already account for around 15% of global electricity consumption, with demand expected to rise sharply as AI expands. Similar concerns have fuelled community opposition to data centre developments in parts of Europe and North America, where residents have questioned whether the economic

benefits justify the environmental costs. In response, New York Governor Kathy Hochul recently signed an executive order enacting a one-year moratorium on the construction of large new data centres. Similar restrictions have been put in place by several other cities in the US. In Europe, Dublin and Frankfurt have introduced stricter controls on the operation of data centres within their limits.

Prateek Aggarwal, senior programme lead at CEWW and one of the authors of the CEWW-Sysmii report, said, "The ministry of electronics and information technology (MeitY) released a draft Data Centre Policy back in 2020 for discussion. However, 16 Indian states have introduced policies or relied on IT and industrial rules to attract data centre projects, with five of them incorporating sustainability-related requirements. As investments in the sector scale up, India now needs an updated national policy that brings greater consistency to data centre performance and sustainability standards."

This, Aggarwal said, could include mandatory disclosure of energy, water and carbon use to enable transparency and benchmarking. Phased Power Usage Effectiveness (PUE) and Water Usage Effectiveness (WUE) performance standards to provide efficiency benchmarks as the sector evolves, an integrated siting tool that considers water, land and grid availability to support informed project planning; and a grid integration framework that enables data centres to deploy battery storage and demand response to contribute to grid flexibility while meeting their power needs.

Different countries offer useful models for India as it develops this framework. The EU mandates energy and water reporting for facilities above 500 kW, as well as waste-heat recovery above 1 MW. China caps the amount of water a facility can use based on its energy load. Singapore and Malaysia link project approvals directly to efficiency, water and carbon metrics. These approaches offer reference points for a policy that supports the continued growth of India's data centre sector while encouraging resource-efficient and grid-responsive infrastructure.



Mangled remains of the car after the accident in Madhya Pradesh's Dhar district on Sunday.

6 killed as truck collides with car in Dhar district

Agencies
letters@hindustantimes.com

BADNAR: Six people were killed and one person sustained critical injuries after a container truck travelling on the wrong side of the road collided with their vehicle in Badnawar, Madhya Pradesh, police said on Sunday. According to initial information from the local police, the container truck driver was found to be under the influence of alcohol, and further action will be initiated in the case.

Speaking to ANI, Dhar District Additional Superintendent of Police (ASP) Vijay Dawar said, "A tragic road accident occurred in Badnawar, in

which six people died. According to the initial information received, a family was returning after visiting Ujjain Mahaleswari. During that time, they were hit from the front by a container coming from the wrong side. "Six people died in this; one is injured and hospitalised, and their condition remains critical. According to the initial information, the driver of the container was found to be under the influence of alcohol. His MLC (Medico-Legal Case) will be conducted, and further action will be taken after registering a case under serious sections. Further probe is underway," the official said.

23 injured as pvt bus falls off bridge after collision in Andhra

PAMIDU: A Bengaluru-bound private bus carrying 34 people, travelling from Hyderabad, fell off a bridge after colliding with a light commercial vehicle (LCV) in Andhra's Anantapur district on Sunday, leaving 23 passengers injured, police said.

Following the collision, both the LCV and the bus fell from the bridge. An FIR has been registered, police said. Of the 34 people on board the bus, it escaped without injuries, while the remaining 23 sustained injuries ranging from minor to serious, a police officer said.

J&K: 28 Tiranga Yatra participants injured as bus overturns

JAMMU: At least 28 women were injured after a mini-bus carrying participants of a Tiranga Yatra overturned on a flyover near the Super Speciality Hospital in Jammu on Sunday night, officials said.

The women, aged between 18 and 25 years, were part of the 'Nari Veerangana' project, an initiative of some BJP-affiliated NGOs. They were returning home after participating in the Tiranga Yatra from Bahu Fort to Mubarak Mandi. The injured were later shifted to Government Medical College hospital.

Claims seen politically motivated: Delhi court in Brij Bhushan order

Arnabjit Sur
letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court, while acquitting former Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) chief Brij Bhushan Singh, had said that the sexual harassment allegations against him were "false" and "fabricated", and part of a "deep conspiracy" which sought to be politically motivated.

Last week, a Delhi court acquitted Singh, former BJP MP from Uttar Pradesh, and Vinod Tomar, former WFI assistant secretary, for trial of evidence, two years after the fact began. In a detailed judgment, parts of which HT sees, additional chief judicial magistrate Ashwini Panwar observed: "I have no hitch in saying that the version given by the victims...discredits the prosecution completely and also shows that the entire allegations are false and fabricated, made against the accused persons in a deep conspiracy which seems to be politically motivated."

The court held that the conspiracy against the accused appeared to have been hatched by "coaches of the Mahadev Academy" and the incident purportedly took place in Mongolia in 2016. The court held: "The discrepancy is not a mere variation in peripheral details; it concerns the fundamental particulars of the alleged occurrence, namely, the country and the year in which the incident purportedly took place."

Over another incident that allegedly took place inside a Delhi stadium in 2018, the court noted that although the alleged occurrence took place in the presence of several people, including family members, coaches and athletes, no independent eyewitness came forward to depose against the



Brij Bhushan Singh

ing purportedly been witnessed by or disclosed to several people. The court dealt with an alleged incident that took place during an Olympic qualification in Mongolia, noting material contradictions in the complainant's versions regarding the time and place of the alleged incident.

It said: "In one statement, the incident was stated to have taken place in Mongolia in 2015; whereas in the subsequent version, the same was stated to have occurred in Mongolia in 2016."

The court held: "The discrepancy is not a mere variation in peripheral details; it concerns the fundamental particulars of the alleged occurrence, namely, the country and the year in which the incident purportedly took place."

Over another incident that allegedly took place inside a Delhi stadium in 2018, the court noted that although the alleged occurrence took place in the presence of several people, including family members, coaches and athletes, no independent eyewitness came forward to depose against the

accused. The court said, "it is not the natural conduct of the persons surrounding and watching her suffer; the latter they could have done to get her out of that situation or confront the accused."

The court said one witness stated that the accused was standing with his hand on the complainant's shoulder, but "there is no reference to having seen any forcible hug or any attempt by PW-5 (one of the complainants) to push the accused away."

The judgement further emphasised the statements of two witnesses who turned hostile during the trial, noting that they told the court they had been made to participate in the allegations at the instance of coaches associated with the Mahadev Academy.

The court said: "They [hostile witnesses] categorically denied that any sexual harassment had been committed against them by the accused and stated that their statements under Section 164 of the CrPC had been given under pressure and threat."

The court further observed that before sitting on a drama, one of the complainants had made no allegations of sexual harassment, and no name of any female wrestler who had faced sexual harassment had been mentioned.

"Then the female wrestlers who were selected came forward and the same/similar allegations were incorporated in the tailor-made formal complaints drafted in a fancy manner, with similar excessive decoration, and the same

were filed before the police," the court held. The judge stated there appeared to be a "similarity in the allegations" made by all victims, with the alleged instances said to have occurred in public spaces in the presence of several people. However, the judge added that there were material contradictions in the versions of the victims and eyewitnesses regarding the claims, creating "more than sufficient reasonable doubt in my mind to discredit the prosecution story."

The court said that of the five victims whose allegations formed the basis of charges against the accused, two had not supported the prosecution's case. They stated that they had been "forced/persuaded" to give their statements at the instance of two prosecution witnesses, the court said.

"Nothing has been proved by the prosecution which shows that these two victims did not support the case of the prosecution due to an overt act attributable to the accused persons," the court held.

The court held: "The allegations appear to be imperfect to be true, seen rehearsed and well-practised as well as planned, more so when the complaints have been filed after a long period of time."

The court also examined the "subsequent conduct" of the witnesses following the start of the trial, observing that they had maintained "cordial relations" with the accused and continued to interact with him at public functions.

SMARTER FINANCIAL DECISIONS START HERE EVERY WEDNESDAY

INTRODUCING
Hindustan Times
YOUR MONEY
PERSONAL FINANCE. MADE SIMPLE.

Better financial decisions begin with better understanding. This weekly series helps you navigate money with greater confidence.



READ EVERY WEDNESDAY



{ IN UTTARAKHAND, PUNJAB, UTTAR PRADESH }

9 kanwariyas die in separate incidents

HTC and Agencies

FATEHGARH SAHIB/HARIWAR/ BUDLAD: At least nine kanwariyas died in separate incidents in Uttarakhand, Punjab and Uttar Pradesh over the last two days, officials said on Sunday.

In Uttarakhand, two Kanwariyas were killed in separate road accidents in Haridwar during the ongoing Shravan Kanwar pilgrimage on Saturday night and Sunday, police said. In two separate incidents, three kanwariyas who had

come to fetch Ganga water in Haridwar went missing after being swept away by the river's strong current in the past two days, police added.

Meanwhile, State Disaster Response Force teams rescued 21 pilgrims from drowning at different ghats and bathing spots during the on Sunday, officials said.

According to the state's Kanwar Mela control cell, the cumulative number of Kanwariyas arriving in Haridwar during the pilgrimage crossed the 38-million mark on Sunday

when the ongoing Shravan Kanwar pilgrimage entered its final and busiest phase.

In Punjab, three kanwariyas were killed while another was seriously injured on Sunday after a car hit them on the Sirhind GT Road, police said.

Punjab Assembly Speaker Kular Singh Sandhu has announced financial assistance of ₹2 lakh each for the bereaved families and free medical treatment for the injured person.

A 35-year-old kanwariya was killed in eight others, including seven children, sustained

burn injuries when they came in contact with the electrically charged generator powering a DJ set up accompanying a group of Kanwar yatrias in Budlad district, UP, police said on Sunday.

Superintendent of Police (City) Abhishek Singh said the incident occurred on Saturday evening in Garhi village under the Kadar Chowk police station area. He said several kanwariyas, including children, were playing and dancing behind the DJ trolley when its generator became electrically charged, causing electric shock.

{ OUR TAKE }

The utility test of the Mecca pact

India's response should involve building on existing ties and forging new ones in West Asia

Vulgus amicitias utilitate probat,' said Ovid, the celebrated — and exiled — Latin poet writing roughly around the time of Christ. Ordinary people forge friendships purely based on utility, is what it means. Pakistan perhaps knows its Ovid well. Should India, then, be worried about the trilateral defence agreement signed in Mecca on August 7 by Saudi Arabia, Pakistan and Turkey? The answer depends on who is asking the question and who is answering it. While the pact deserves more than the familiar "closely following developments" handout from the ministry of external affairs (MEA), there is certainly no need for alarmism. The Mecca pact, in essence, formally binds Pakistan, a nuclear power, to two of the Islamic world's most consequential States in a NATO-style arrangement. The utility of this pact in the face of an actual conflict at a later date is of lesser consequence for India than the signalling it does at the moment.

Pakistan, enjoying inexplicable goodwill in the White House after decades, has attained prestige precisely when New Delhi would prefer Islamabad isolated. Anything that bolsters Pakistani army chief Asim Munir's stature is a strategic eyesore for India. Pacts such as these achieve exactly that. More importantly, and almost contradictorily for Pakistan, the pact signals eroding confidence in the US' security guarantees across West Asia, as exposed in the ongoing Iran conflict. India has invested heavily in the region in terms of energy imports, remittances, and defence ties with both Riyadh and Tel Aviv.

India's response to the pact should mean building on these existing ties and forging some new ones. Quiet work with Riyadh and Ankara, individually, should continue as well. Since the Mecca pact is still ambiguous in terms of how it will translate on the ground, this can be met with strategic clarity of our own. It is still not a binding military alliance and lacks the institutional heft of NATO. The partners — Turkey, Saudi Arabia, and Pakistan — may want to signal a formidable Sunni solidarity, but they have, even in the recent past, displayed divergence over issues like Israel's operations in Gaza. India must ignore the din of divisive domestic politics and work towards planting firmer feet internationally.

OTT regulation: Much easier said than done

As the government mulls creating a statutory framework to regulate "offensive" OTT content, there are three points that need consideration.

The first is parity. Movies screened in theatres and cable TV content are governed under independent laws (the Cinematograph Act, which provides for the film certification board, and the Cable Television Networks (Regulation) Act, respectively). However, OTT content is regulated through a light-touch, three-tiered structure framed in the IT Rules 2021. This structure is premised on self-regulation, by content producers first and self-regulating bodies next, before government oversight kicks in. In sharp contrast is the censorship regime that exists for movies.

That said, there are enough examples of OTT platforms removing controversial content. *Satju* being a recent one. This brings us to the second consideration — what the planned statute seeks to achieve. A parliamentary committee report talks of post-release screening for socially or morally offensive content, by an independent panel. To regulate "offensive" content, the government must very clearly define what will be perceived as such — and this could be the Achilles' heel of such legislative enterprise. The range of OTT content that could be ideologically offensive than non-partisan such is vast. So, any regulatory instance that appears partisan only lends to censorship controversies.

The third consideration was first talked about for movies, but the underlying principle applies to OTT too. The Shyam Bengal committee, in 2016, had recommended changes to the Cinematograph Act to focus on age-based certification with explicit and abundant warnings about specific bits that could affect one group's sensibilities or the other's, rather than wholesale censorship. This is even more applicable now given the number of internet-mediated ways to feed censorship or bans. This perhaps would make for a more mature viewing culture, where a viewer is warned enough in advance to avoid watching anything that they don't find palatable.

The government must do the hard yards if a future statute is not to be rendered infructuous in practice.

Imran Khan case: US ambivalence on democracy

Washington may view a managed political accommodation for Khan more favourably than an unconditional release

Three years after his arrest, Pakistan's former Prime Minister Imran Khan remains incarcerated, with no definitive indication that his release is imminent. Although recent speculation has centred on the possibility of a medical release, these discussions remain contingent on broader political calculations rather than legal momentum.

At 73, Khan continues to be held primarily in solitary confinement at the Al Ta'arun Prison in Rawalpindi, serving sentences in multiple cases, including the Toshakhana and Al-Qadir Trust convictions, which both he and the Pakistan Tehreek-e-Insaf (PTI) are politically engineered by Pakistan's military establishment in concert with the Shehbaz Sharif government. Khan continues to face domestic legal proceedings, ensuring that even favourable outcomes in individual cases would not necessarily secure his freedom. His deteriorating health has injected new urgency into the debate. Reports throughout 2026 suggest that Khan has suffered severe vision loss in one eye following central retinal vein occlusion, with his family and advisers attributing the damage to delayed medical intervention. They have also repeatedly highlighted prolonged isolation, restricted access to lawyers and family members, and worsening overall health. Against this backdrop, PTI has sought to mobilise public opinion

through nationwide protests, particularly around the symbolic three-year anniversary of Khan's imprisonment.

Recent media reports suggest that informal discussions are underway regarding a possible release on humanitarian or medical grounds. This would resemble political accommodations extended to figures such as Nawaz Sharif. Yet, the prospects remain uncertain. The government insists that Khan's fate rests with the judiciary while rejecting the case for medical bail. Equally significant is the widespread belief that Khan is unlikely to accept conditions such as political silence or exile, while the military establishment appears reluctant to release a leader who continues to pose a command significant popular support and has consistently resisted political compromise. Given the slow pace of judicial appeals and the absence of a broader political settlement, claims of an imminent release remain speculative.

The trajectory of US-Pakistan relations has become increasingly detached from Pakistan's domestic political contestation. Since Donald Trump's return to office, bilateral engagement has been rebuilt primarily through historic events such as the World Lion Day celebration at Barda, rather than its civilian political context. Army chief Asim Munir has emerged as Washington's principal interlocutor, reflecting a broader shift toward a security-driven relationship centred on counterterrorism cooperation, regional crisis management, and military engagement, including continued support for Pakistan's Rafal jets. While this framework, Khan's potential release would matter less as a demo-

cratic milestone than as a variable affecting Pakistan's internal stability.

A carefully negotiated release, particularly one accompanied by political restraint or temporary exile, could help reduce domestic polarisation and recurring political mobilisation that continue to complicate governance and economic recovery. Such an outcome would likely be viewed in Washington as contributing to the stability of a strategically useful partner without fundamentally altering existing patterns of bilateral cooperation.

Conversely, a politically empowered Khan returning to active politics would introduce fresh uncertainty into Pakistan's internal balance of power. His popularity could challenge the military-backed political order that has underpinned Pakistan's recent engagement with the US. While some Republican lawmakers and figures close to the Trump administration have advocated Khan's release, official US policy has treated his legal predicament as an internal Pakistani matter. Washington's broader strategic engagement has remained anchored in State-to-State, and increasingly military-to-military, relations rather than support for any particular political actor. US-Pakistan relations remain driven far more by strategic utility than by democracy promotion or human rights conditionality.

A managed political accommodation would be viewed more favourably as a release that precipitates renewed confrontation between Khan and the military establishment. Khan has consistently argued that his removal through the April 2022 no-confidence vote was facilitated by



US-Pakistan relations remain driven far more by strategic utility than by democracy promotion or human rights conditionality.

US pressure arising from disagreements over Pakistan's foreign policy, particularly his independent approach toward Russia and broader geopolitical positioning. Central to this narrative has been the so-called diplomatic "cynicism," documenting a March 2022 conversation in which US official Donald Lu reportedly suggested that bilateral relations would improve following Khan's removal. While the US has denied orchestrating regime change, this has remained a defining feature of PTI's political narrative.

Ironically, Khan's imprisonment has coincided with an improvement in US-Pakistan relations. As Pakistan's military leadership restored close ties with Washington, external pressure over Khan's detention steadily diminished. Although the Biden administration witnessed congressional concern, human rights criticism, and international scrutiny, including findings by the UN Working Group on Arbitrary Detention, these concerns never fundamentally altered the strategic calculus governing bilateral relations.

Under the second Trump administration, this trend has become even more pronounced. Engagement has increasingly focused on Pakistan's military cooperation and regional diplomacy over governance concerns. While individual American lawmakers and political figures have continued to advocate Khan's release, official US policy has largely prioritised maintaining con-

structural relations with the country's existing power structure. Khan's own history of anti-American rhetoric has further limited the emergence of bipartisan support for him within Washington. As US-Pakistan ties have deepened through military channels, international leverage over Khan's incarceration has correspondingly weakened.

The debate surrounding Imran Khan's possible release reflects the broader realities of Pakistan's political system. Legal arguments and humanitarian considerations remain secondary to the calculations of the country's civil-military balance. Any meaningful change in Khan's status will thus emerge through political negotiation rather than judicial resolution alone.

Similarly, the evolution of US-Pakistan relations underscores a familiar pattern in international politics: strategic interests have consistently outweighed democratic concerns. Washington's renewed engagement with Pakistan has been constructed around the post-Khan political order, with the military establishment serving as the principal pillar of bilateral cooperation. Unless Pakistan's internal political equilibrium undergoes a significant transformation, Khan's future — and the international response to it — will continue to be determined primarily by domestic power politics rather than external pressure.

Harsh V Pant is vice president, ORF. The views expressed are personal

How India brought the lion back from the brink

Every year on August 10, stakeholders worldwide celebrate World Lion Day. This historic event during last year's World Lion Day celebration at Barda, commemorating lions' return to this stunning landscape. A central element of India's success in lion conservation is the active support and engagement of local communities. These communities not only admire lions but also accept their presence. Many pastoral and agricultural groups hold the lion in high regard, considering them protectors of their culture, and tend to view livestock losses as a natural consequence rather than responding with retaliation.

This goodwill has been cultivated over generations and upheld through various programmes. For instance, the Gir Samvad Setu initiative, started in 2019, regularly brings forest staff and villagers together to discuss wildlife conservation, resolve conflicts, and address concerns directly. Additional community stewardship is provided by honorary wildlife wardens, local age-guards (community leaders), and hundreds of trained eco-guides and safari vehicle drivers. Members of eco-development committees and sarpanchs are also involved whenever possible, to ensure local participation. Farmers have also started seeing lions with admiration. Many say lions help keep crop-damaging animals such as nilgai and wild pigs in check, acting as a natural population control species. Farmers in the lion territory often say, in the local idiom, that they sleep more peacefully hearing a lion roar.

The 16th Asiatic Lion Motivation Festivals (May 2025) reveal there are 891 lions in India, a 32% rise from 674 in 2020. Under the environmentally sensitive leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the lions' range has expanded from around 30,000 sq. km in 2020 to nearly 35,000 sq. km, covering 11 districts. In comparison, in 1990, their range was only about 6,600 sq. km, representing over a 400% increase. The current population seems robust, with 196 adult males, 330 adult females, and 225 cubs, indicating that lions are thriving, breeding, and raising their young across the area.

Several factors have contributed to this recovery. The main element is the strict legal protection that has eliminated poaching, except for a 2007 incident. Additionally, the revival of wild prey populations — such as spotted deer, sambar, blue bull, and wild pig — has been crucial. Wild prey now constitutes about 74% of the lions' diet, compared to only 26% in 1974.

The landscape approach's expansion has been equally significant. Rather than restricting conservation to Gir protected areas, India extended it to the broader Asiatic lion landscape, encompassing protected areas, forests, grasslands, seascapes, and multi-use landscapes. This broader focus offers lions more space to find new territories.

A truly inspiring part of this story is the return of Asiatic lions to Barda Wildlife Sanctuary in Gujarat. By 1879, lions were extirpated from the Barda area, and for more than 144 years, the forest lost their roar. Yet, in January 2023, a male lion naturally dispersed into Barda and was soon followed by female lions. By 2025, Barda was home to a population of 17 lions, marking a remarkable natural comeback after almost 150 years. This achievement was not accidental; it resulted from deliberate, science-based conservation strategies, habitat restoration, protected corridors, prey population enhancement, and community involvement. Today,

Barda is celebrated globally as an example of big cat recovery. I was fortunate to witness this historic event during last year's World Lion Day celebration at Barda, commemorating lions' return to this stunning landscape. A central element of India's success in lion conservation is the active support and engagement of local communities. These communities not only admire lions but also accept their presence. Many pastoral and agricultural groups hold the lion in high regard, considering them protectors of their culture, and tend to view livestock losses as a natural consequence rather than responding with retaliation.

This goodwill has been cultivated over generations and upheld through various programmes. For instance, the Gir Samvad Setu initiative, started in 2019, regularly brings forest staff and villagers together to discuss wildlife conservation, resolve conflicts, and address concerns directly. Additional community stewardship is provided by honorary wildlife wardens, local age-guards (community leaders), and hundreds of trained eco-guides and safari vehicle drivers. Members of eco-development committees and sarpanchs are also involved whenever possible, to ensure local participation. Farmers have also started seeing lions with admiration. Many say lions help keep crop-damaging animals such as nilgai and wild pigs in check, acting as a natural population control species. Farmers in the lion territory often say, in the local idiom, that they sleep more peacefully hearing a lion roar.

The 16th Asiatic Lion Motivation Festivals (May 2025) reveal there are 891 lions in India, a 32% rise from 674 in 2020. Under the environmentally sensitive leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the lions' range has expanded from around 30,000 sq. km in 2020 to nearly 35,000 sq. km, covering 11 districts. In comparison, in 1990, their range was only about 6,600 sq. km, representing over a 400% increase. The current population seems robust, with 196 adult males, 330 adult females, and 225 cubs, indicating that lions are thriving, breeding, and raising their young across the area.

Several factors have contributed to this recovery. The main element is the strict legal protection that has eliminated poaching, except for a 2007 incident. Additionally, the revival of wild prey populations — such as spotted deer, sambar, blue bull, and wild pig — has been crucial. Wild prey now constitutes about 74% of the lions' diet, compared to only 26% in 1974.

The landscape approach's expansion has been equally significant. Rather than restricting conservation to Gir protected areas, India extended it to the broader Asiatic lion landscape, encompassing protected areas, forests, grasslands, seascapes, and multi-use landscapes. This broader focus offers lions more space to find new territories.

A truly inspiring part of this story is the return of Asiatic lions to Barda Wildlife Sanctuary in Gujarat. By 1879, lions were extirpated from the Barda area, and for more than 144 years, the forest lost their roar. Yet, in January 2023, a male lion naturally dispersed into Barda and was soon followed by female lions. By 2025, Barda was home to a population of 17 lions, marking a remarkable natural comeback after almost 150 years. This achievement was not accidental; it resulted from deliberate, science-based conservation strategies, habitat restoration, protected corridors, prey population enhancement, and community involvement. Today,

Bhupender Yadav is Union minister for environment, forest & climate change. The views expressed are personal

{ RC BHARGAVA } CHAIRMAN, MARUTI SUZUKI

I would urge the government, including State governments, to proceed faster on the road of reforms

In a message to shareholders

{ STRAIGHTFORWARD }

Shashi Shekhar

Retaining homegrown talent China, US style

Singapore's first Prime Minister Lee Kuan Yew once told the island-nation's Parliament, "If you have a political system that does not attract the best to the government, then you are going to get second-rate people running the country, and you will get second-rate results." Our country faces the same challenge as the 80th year of Independent India approaches. We will have to work towards conserving and promoting our talent. Our growth, social progress and security depend on the exodus of more than 180 scientists from India's Space Research Organisation (ISRO) highlighted an ominous reality. Unfortunately, ISRO isn't alone. The Army, defence research organisations, IITs and IIMs too, see serious attrition. Barring the civil services, there's a dearth of talent everywhere else. Why?

Two reasons compel professionals to leave government employment. The private sector offers significantly higher salaries, which are linked to business growth. And increasingly, professionals are also offered long-term contracts, ensuring stable employment. On the other hand, the government sector regulations on retirement and benefits remind you of the colonial times. Adding insult to injury, red-tapism remains commonplace.

Emerging areas, such as space, defence, and other critical tech, are the main reason for the exodus from the government sector. How can we turn this "brain drain" into "brain gain"?

The US, China, and Europe offer learnings. In the US, NASA and the defence department allow their scientists and technicians to work with private agencies and contractors — companies such as SpaceX and Blue Origin are flourishing under such arrangements. In Europe, scientists and professors can work with private companies while still teaching in universities. They have the option to work as independent consultants. This way, they not only have government employment but also a chance to increase their income, with the billing made out to the private sector. China has many examples of the "reverse brain drain". The Chinese government is running more than 200 programmes to attract researchers from around the world. The reform got a definitive boost in 2008, with the "1,000 talent plan", under which scientists and academics of Chinese origin, working in the West, were offered lucrative work opportunities in China. Inspired by its success, Beijing launched the "Qiming Programme" — offering

one million yuan as signing amount for joining government-run research programmes. If a person's work meets expectations, they are offered a salary of two to four million yuan. Scientists get easy start-up grants of five to eight million yuan. Regional and provincial administrations offer them other facilities and benefits on top of these.

The Chinese government takes the responsibility of settling its scientists, researchers, and their families. Their children get admission in the best of schools. Elderly parents are given all necessary help and spouses get a government job commensurate with their qualification and experience. The scientists are categorised as gold, silver, and bronze depending upon their achievements. If a Nobel laureate or a senior executive from Fortune 500 companies wants to settle in China, they immediately get VIP facilities and millions of dollars in grants.

China knows that talent can't be retained by merely appealing to nationalism. To encourage homegrown scientists, repatriate those working in the West, and ensure growth and prosperity, whatever they need or desire must be offered. The results of Beijing's efforts are visible. China is a contender for the title of global leader of futuristic technologies.

What's India doing in this direction? The government has initiated a "lateral entry" programme for senior government executives and offered many facilities to promote the startup ecosystem. This is the reason our defence exports have risen to \$4.5 billion in the last 10 years. We have become exporters instead of remain solely importers. Iro scientists have received various awards and recognitions. The Centre created ISpace to allow them to contribute to the private sector. The founders of Skyroot Aerospace, which has crossed many milestones in just four years, earlier worked for ISro.

However, we are still to create a composite structure that involves government agencies/firms, the corporate sector, and start-ups. Only this system will be able to retain and channel talent at home and inspire diaspora talent to return. I am reminded of the famous Indianologist, James Goldsmith, who once said, "If you pay peanuts, you get monkeys." We aspire to become an economic superpower. Retaining and promoting talent is the only way to achieve it. Why don't we make it a pledge for this Independence Day?

Shashi Shekhar is a senior editor, Hindustan. The views expressed are personal

Netanyahu rejects
Gaza plan in new
break from Trump

Agence France-Presse
letters@hindustantimes.com

JERUSALEM: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu on Sunday rejected a US-led Gaza plan endorsed by Hamas, putting distance between himself and President Donald Trump as he tries to shore up his base ahead of close elections.

After more than a week of gradually escalating criticism of the plan, and despite receiving assurances that Israel would not need to start withdrawing in Gaza immediately, Netanyahu explicitly opposed the deal following pushback from his right-wing allies.

"Israel rejects the 15-point document," Netanyahu said, referring to the plan Hamas agreed to in late July.

The Israeli military "will not carry out any withdrawal until Hamas is genuinely disarmed, and will continue to thwart threats against our forces and our citizens", he told a cabinet meeting.

Netanyahu described Trump, who had hailed the Gaza deal as a milestone for peace, as "our greatest friend in the White House" - but quickly made clear he was willing to challenge him, saying Israel was raising its objections with the United States.

"They have ideas; some of them are acceptable to us and some are not, and we know how to stand our ground on these matters," he said.

Netanyahu, Israel's longest-serving leader, is running even or trailing in some polls ahead of October 27 elections, the country's first since the devastating October 7, 2023 attack by Hamas that sparked the Gaza war.



An armed Israeli soldier in Nablus, West Bank on Sunday. AFP

Polls show that the Gaza plan is unpopular with Netanyahu's right-wing base, and far-right members of his cabinet have urged him to kill it.

Hamas, days after selecting a new leader, Khalil al-Hayya, announced it supported the Gaza plan, and has since called on Washington to push Netanyahu to accept it.

"We expect the mediators and the American guarantor to pressure Netanyahu and his government to adhere to the roadmap, and not obstruct the process for internal political and electoral reasons," Bassem Naim, a member of Hamas's political bureau, told AFP.

Hamas in a statement said it was still committed to the plan. - Friction with Trump - Netanyahu until recently campaigned on the strength of his relationship with Trump, who has taken unprecedented steps to back Israel, including moving the US embassy to Jerusalem.

Trump joined Netanyahu in late February in launching a war against Iran, but the two diverged when Trump sought a ceasefire and subsequent settlement to the conflict as it sapped his popularity and sent oil prices soaring.

Netanyahu told his cabinet that "with an agreement or without an agreement, as long as I am prime minister, Iran will not have nuclear weapons", a goal he has long alleged Tehran is pursuing.

Netanyahu last week also ordered fresh strikes on Lebanon in response to what Israel called a ceasefire violation by Iran-backed Hezbollah, just as Israel and Lebanon were holding US-mediated talks.

The Gaza plan was the latest stage in a US-brokered ceasefire announced in October that has reduced, but not ended, Israeli operations there.

Hamas said it would surrender weapons to a nascent Palestinian governing body. The plan said Israel would begin pulling out forces in tandem with the disarmament, a timeline it adamantly rejected.

Houthis attack Saudi Aramco refinery

Reuters

letters@hindustantimes.com

CAIRO/DUBAI/ADEN: Yemen's Iran-aligned Houthis have attacked Saudi Aramco's Jazan refinery, they said on Sunday, two days after the kingdom signed a defence pact with Turkey and Pakistan in response to growing regional instability from the US-Israeli war on Iran.

The alliance with Sunni Muslim US allies, Turkey and Pakistan, is intended to strengthen collective deterrence against any act of aggression and stipulates that an armed attack against any

of the three would be regarded as an attack on all.

It was not clear whether or how either Pakistan or Turkey would join in any Saudi response to the latest attacks.

The Houthis declared a naval blockade against Saudi Arabia in the Red Sea last month, citing what they said was a Saudi siege on them, an allegation Riyadh denies.

The Saudi energy ministry said a fire had broken out at the refinery but was later extinguished with no injuries and authorities were dealing with the incident, without giving a cause.

The Houthis used a drone to target the refinery, military spokesperson Yahya Saeed posted on X. They had struck Aramco sites before in Jazan, which processes 400,000 barrels of crude oil per day in southwestern Saudi Arabia. They had also hit Yanbu on the Red Sea.

In a separate statement, Saeed said the Houthis carried out missile and drone strikes on the Yemeni Red Sea port city of Mocha. The historic port is controlled by the Aden-based government, which is internationally recognised and backed by Riyadh.

Three Yemeni government sources told Reuters air defences were engaging drones launched by the Houthis towards the commercial quay and storage in the port. They did not specify they were Saudi air defences.

Saeed said the Houthi strikes targeted Saudi troops and weapons arsenal in the area. There was no Saudi comment on the attacks in Yemen.

The Yemeni military spokesperson said the attack on the port killed seven people. Yemen said in a statement that the attack caused severe damage to the port's infrastructure.

PENTAGON PUSHES
U.S. ARMS FIRMS TO
RAISE PRODUCTION

WASHINGTON: The Pentagon is pressing the US defence industry to accelerate production of weapons to help replenish its diminished stockpile of munitions, including those depleted in the ongoing war with Iran.

It wrote to industry leaders, giving them no more than 21 days to submit plans to drive significantly faster delivery schedules and increased production for critical capabilities.

AP



Himanshi Khurana and Abdul Ghafoori

MAN HELD FOR
2025 MURDER OF
INDIAN IN CANADA

Anirudh Bhattacharyya
letters@hindustantimes.com

TORONTO: Canadian law enforcement has announced the arrest of 32-year-old Abdul Ghafoori and charged him in connection with the murder of 30-year-old Indian national Himanshi Khurana in Toronto in December 2025.

A release issued by Toronto Police Service (TPS) on Saturday said Ghafoori was arrested on Friday and charged with first-degree murder. "Members of the Toronto Police Fugitive Squad and Homicide and Missing Persons Unit liaised with national and international policing partners to facilitate the accused's return to Canada," the release noted. However, it did not mention which country he had fled to after allegedly committing the killing.

Canadian law enforcement had issued a countrywide warrant for Ghafoori's arrest after the murder occurred on December 20 last year.

Indian on the run after girlfriend's
murder in US caught in Germany

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: A 20-year-old Indian man in the US allegedly killed his girlfriend, a US citizen who planned to break up with him because he had physically and sexually assaulted her, and then fled to Germany where he was arrested before he could take a flight to India.

The accused, identified as Varun Bhatnagar by the authorities, strangled 19-year-old Julissa Rubi Salazar inside her apartment near the University of Arizona in Tucson, Arizona, on Thursday, the New York Post reported.

Bhatnagar was a business analytics student at the university, according to his YouTube channel, before he was expelled following a fight. He also recently lost his job, which put his visa status in jeopardy and made it difficult for him to pay rent. KOLD local news website reported, Salazar was also a student at the university.

The victim's roommates told KOLD that they heard loud screaming coming from her



Julissa Rubi Salazar and Varun Bhatnagar

room that lasted for several minutes a day before she was found dead. Police found Salazar with strangulation marks and scratches on her neck. Her phone and bank cards were missing.

Police said that Bhatnagar killed Salazar and then stole her phone and bank cards. He used the bank cards to take a ride to Tucson International Airport from where he took a flight to Houston, Texas. From there he boarded a flight to Berlin, Germany.

Police issued an arrest warrant and immediately informed the FBI, who informed their legal attaché in Berlin. Bhatnagar was arrested when he arrived in Berlin. Police said that he planned to take a flight to India.

Boat capsizes in NY
Harbor, woman and
5-month-old baby die

NEW YORK: A 22-foot Bayliner speedboat capsized in New York Harbor on Saturday night, killing a 27-year-old woman and her 5-month-old girl, and its operator is facing criminal charges. Twelve people were

rescued from the water.

Oz probes near-miss
collision of 2 planes on
tarmac in Sydney

SYDNEY: A Jetstar A320 and a Qatar Airways Boeing 777 narrowly avoided colliding on the tarmac at Sydney airport on Sunday, officials said as they began a probe.

The Jetstar was taxiing for takeoff when its crew saw the other plane being towed close by. Both stopped. A crew member on the Jetstar was injured.

8 political parties
form 'Progressive
Front' bloc in Nepal

KATHMANDU: Eight Nepalese

political parties have announced the formation of a new alliance named the "Progressive Front" based on "shared political issues and common agendas." The alliance comprises, PSP, JP, AJP, NUPN, PLP, NSPP, BSPN and KRM. They said they aim to end all types of discrimination against Madhesis and minorities.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

EVERYONE
HAS A THEORY
OURS HAS
THE NUMBERS

Hindustan Times
NUMBER THEORY

Go beyond opinions with evidence-backed insights that uncover hidden trends, challenge assumptions and reveal a deeper understanding of the stories shaping India and the world.

READ NUMBER THEORY IN HINDUSTAN TIMES



Refiners see cost spike as US cracks whip on Russia

Import costs to rise as Senate allows US president to impose tariffs up to 100%

Ritural Baruah & Namita Mishra

ritural.baruah@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: India's state-run oil refiners are bracing for higher crude procurement costs and tighter availability as they prepare to buy oil for delivery after September amid the prospect of steep tariffs by the US on countries importing Russian crude, two people aware of the development said. "State-owned refiners have supplies tied up for the next 50 days, so an impact of the bill is not expected immediately," an executive with a refiner said, requesting anonymity.

Tenders are likely to be floated around mid-August for supplies beyond September. That, however, needs to be seen as to what is the availability and also the pricing."

The concern follows the US Senate's passage of the Lindsey O. Graham sanctions bill, which allows US president to impose tariffs up to 100% on countries that support Russia's war in Ukraine.



India's crude oil import bill surged 60% year-on-year to nearly \$49.8 billion in the April-June quarter. AFP

which will be taken up in the House of Representatives next month after the Congress returns from its summer recess. The Act empowers the US president to impose tariffs of up to 100% on countries that are among the top five importers of Russian oil and gas, including China and India, which is the world's third-largest oil importer and fourth-largest refiner. Russian crude accounts for about 48% of imports by India's state-run refiners.

India may fall back on West Asian crude if Russian oil is

sanctioned, but the cost of the barrels which are coming in through the Suez Canal would be higher, while elevated insurance premiums are also affecting shipments on routes outside the Strait of Hormuz due to the ongoing West Asia conflict.

A second person aware of developments said expensive spot purchases already account for 85% of India's crude imports due to the supply constraints. "Supplies would be somewhat secured as oil from Venezuela, the US, UAE and Oman are

expected to come in, but pricing will be the key concern." India's crude oil import bill has already surged 60% year-on-year to nearly \$49.8 billion in the April-June quarter, even as import volumes fell to around 60 million tonnes from 62.6 million tonnes a year ago, suggesting that higher prices rather than demand were the main driver of the increase.

With India importing nearly 90% of its crude oil requirement, every \$1 a barrel increase in prices adds about \$18,000 crore to its annual import bill, underscoring the stakes for the world's third-largest oil importer. Brent crude was trading above \$80 a barrel on Friday, leaving refiners facing a relatively high price base even before any supply shock from sanctions.

Queries emailed to the Union ministry of petroleum and natural gas and the state-run refiners remained unanswered till press time.

Anisur Rahman, professor at the Centre for West Asia studies at Jamia Millia Islamia University, said India's purchases of Russian crude might fall if the sanctions are implemented.

Network, rich clients fuel foreign banks' FCNR flight

Subhansha Shaikh & Shayan Ghosh

subhansha.shaikh@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: Backed by a global network and wealthy clientele, India's foreign banks are flexing their muscle in attracting dollar deposits, despite their under-sized presence in the local deposit market.

Foreign banks, which had barely \$603 million in foreign currency non-resident bank deposits on 5 June when the central bank announced the concessional dollar swap window, managed to clock \$8.97 billion by 30 July. Three foreign banks — HSBC, Standard Chartered Bank, and DBS Bank India — led the inflows.

Experts said that what worked in their favour is the availability of customers across the world and access to more dollars. For local banks, attracting such deposits would entail raising money in dollars and then lending to customers for deposits.

The surge is being driven by foreign banks' superior access to dollar liquidity, said Abhishek Dhanraj, founder at NeoStrat Advisors LLP. Global banks have much larger funding lines and counterparty credit limits with overseas institutions, allowing them to mobilise dollars quickly



HSBC, Standard Chartered Bank, and DBS Bank India led the inflows. ISTOCKPHOTO

whenever an opportunity arises, he said. "Foreign banks have much larger limits with dollar deposit sources, so they are able to raise much more," he said. "Every bank which raises deposits needs to have a limit with their counterparty banks. If somebody is going to place an FCNR deposit with the SBI, they need to have limits with SBI to be able to lend to SBI."

Among the biggest gainers, HSBC saw outstanding FCNR deposits jump from \$20.26 million to \$6.26 billion, while Standard Chartered Bank, which had no FCNR deposits on June 5, had mobilised \$1.86 billion by 30 July. DBS Bank India more than doubled its outstanding deposits to \$613.55 million from \$28.27 million over the same period.

On an outstanding basis — the total amount of deposits at a

given point in time — private sector banks dominated the segment, with \$25.7 billion in such deposits as of 30 July, up 72%, while public sector banks were close behind at \$25.6 billion, a 53% increase over the period. Foreign lenders have narrowed the gap in just under two months, reflecting their ability to tap global dollar pools efficiently.

Foreign banks have traditionally not been big players in the deposit market in India, with their collective share at 4.8% in end-December 2025. In comparison, state-owned banks had a market share of 57.9%, while private banks had a 36.1% share. However, Diwanji of NeoStrat believes the current trend may not permanently alter the competition. "It's only temporary," he said, adding that only foreign banks with a branch presence in India can directly mobilise such deposits under the scheme.

A spokesperson for HSBC declined to comment. Emails sent to Standard Chartered Bank and DBS Bank India remained unanswered. The RBI's FCNR deposit facility, announced alongside temporary relaxations to attract foreign currency inflows and support the rupee, has triggered intense competition among banks to mobilise NRI deposits.

GOVT WEIGHS ₹15,000-CRORE CCEA BAR FOR FDI APPROVALS

Press Trust of India

feedback@pitrindia.com

NEW DELHI: The government is considering a proposal to raise the threshold for foreign direct investment proposals requiring approval from the Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) to ₹15,000 crore from ₹5,000 crore at present to further improve the country's investment climate, according to sources. The Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs (CCEA) is a high-level committee headed by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Its members include key Union Cabinet ministers such as the Home Minister and Finance Minister.

As per the existing foreign direct investment (FDI) policy, in case of proposals involving total foreign equity inflow of more than ₹5,000 crore, the competent authority places the application for consideration of the CCEA. Below this limit, respective line ministries take a decision. The existing limit has remained unchanged since November 2015.

Sources said that prevailing economic conditions, inflation, the growing scale of investments over the years, and the objective of promoting ease of doing business necessitate a review of the existing threshold.

Earlier, a committee of secretaries, in its meeting, also suggested upward revision of the CCEA approval limit for FDI proposals requiring the government approval route.

The proposal is at a discussion stage, they said. The government is also considering a proposal to ease FDI norms for downstream investments to boost overseas fund inflows and create jobs.

As per the proposal, the government is considering exempting indirect foreign investment in Indian companies from obtaining its fresh approval where the upstream domestic firm has already received such approval. The investments have crossed \$1.6 trillion during April 2000 and March 2026.

The curious case of the old iPhone that refuses to get any cheaper

Shouvik Das

shouvik.das@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Turning the mantra of depreciation on its head, refurbished iPhones are actually getting more expensive as they get older.

For instance, a two-year-old iPhone 15 is now selling for around ₹48,000 on refurbished phone platforms. Mint research across refurbished smartphone platforms such as Cashify, ReFit and Control2 showed.

That is nearly 20% more than the ₹25,000 that a similarly aged iPhone 12 cost three years ago.

More strikingly, a used iPhone 12 is available at about the same price even today, despite having been launched six years ago. The unusual price behaviour shows a combination of rising prices of new smartphones, strong demand for Apple devices and a shortage of phones entering this market.

With consumers holding on to their devices for longer, retailers are finding it harder to procure used iPhones even as more buyers eye this relatively affordable way into the Apple ecosystem.

According to Yug Bhatia,

founder of Gurugram-based used smartphone retail platform, Control2, the effect on customers is compounded. "If they want to spend the same amount, they get a much older phone, or else they end up spending double for a new phone."

Used Android smartphones, including those from Samsung, are also seeing a similar trend, but industry executives and analysts said the sharpest increases have been in iPhones.

Nakul Kumar, co-founder of Cashify, India's largest used-electronics retail platform, said this trend has emerged over the past

six months across laptops and mobile phones, partly because new-device prices have risen with memory-chip costs.

"With new devices getting more expensive by 40% or even more in some cases, refurbished and renewed devices are often becoming the only affordable options available for many consumers looking to upgrade their mobile phones," Kumar said. In the case of iPhones, though, he attributed the rise in refurbished prices primarily to strong demand.

The demand is showing up in sales volumes as well.

Saket Saurav, co-founder and chief executive of ReFit Global, another refurbished-electronics platform, said the company expects to sell 800,000 refurbished mobile phones this fiscal, with iPhones accounting for nearly 18%. Last fiscal, it sold about 600,000 phones, of which 12% were iPhones. That means its iPhone sales are expected to roughly double in absolute numbers this fiscal. "Much of this demand is generated from tier-II markets and beyond," Saurav said.

The growth is these retailers to open more physical stores and

also use new-phone market strategies to bring in buyers, including monthly instalments, one-year warranties that can be extended, insurance and repair services.

The growth in demand is running into a supply constraint that echoes the new-phone market. "Even though there is strong demand, customers are holding on to their phones for much longer than before, which means that I'm only able to supply just about 50% of my demand," Saurav said.

Bhatia said Control2 is paying 30-40% more for old phones to

secure supplies, but is still unable to procure enough.

"We're targeting sales of 100,000 units of refurbished iPhones this fiscal," he added.

The supply crunch could keep refurbished-phone prices high, and analysts expect the launch of Apple's next-generation iPhones to further disrupt the depreciation cycle.

Tarun Pathak, director research at market research agency Counterpoint India, sees the iPhone 18 priced nearly 10% higher. "Once it does, the iPhone 17 will continue to be priced at its current pricing only."

ED CHARGES SHEETS RCOM, RELIANCE INFRASTRUCTURE

HT Correspondent

letters@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has filed two separate charge sheets in connection with its money laundering probes against Reliance Communications Limited (RCOM) and Reliance Infrastructure Ltd. respectively, the agency said on Sunday.

The charge sheets were filed before a special court in Delhi under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act on Saturday. In the first charge sheet, the ED said RCOM, Reliance Telecom Ltd (RTL), and senior executives including Gautam Bhatia Doshi, Sateesh Seth and Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, among others, have been arraigned as accused.

According to the agency, its investigation found that fresh credit facilities were repeatedly used to repay, rotate and "evergreen" earlier domestic and foreign liabilities instead of being used for the purposes for which they were sanctioned. The funds, it alleged, were routed through group companies, purpose-built conduit entities, multiple bank accounts and liquid mutual funds; used to service earlier External Commercial Borrowings and Foreign Currency Convertible Bonds (FCCBs); and presented as legitimate business expenditure or receipt.

The ED further alleged that the scheme had commenced by at least 2007 and continued thereafter as a connected course of criminal activity. It said loan proceeds were diverted to group companies such as Reliance Infrastructure Ltd and Reliance Capital Ltd, and were also allegedly used to purchase personal assets for promoters outside India. The agency further alleged that funds were used to service liabilities in a manner that artificially inflated RCOM's profits.

The ED has quantified the alleged proceeds of crime at ₹40,185.55 crore, which it said represents the total outstanding amount defaulted by the borrower entities to consortium banks, financial institutions and bondholders.

In the second charge sheet, the ED said Reliance Infrastructure Ltd, Sateesh Seth and others have been named as accused.

Messages sent to the Reliance group did not elicit a response till the time of going to press.

{ THE CROSSWORDS }

CRYPTIC CLUES

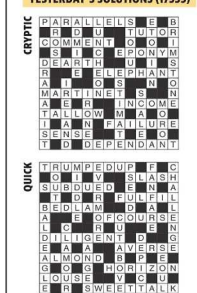
ACROSS

1. Phoney admission of poverty takes in a good man (10)
5. Friends back strike (4)
9. Describing a boom in the travel industry (5)
10. Support for a poor settler (7)
11. Their job is to keep down correspondence (12)
13. Owns permits (6)
14. Leader of a press gang (6)
17. Successor clearly seen (4-8)
20. Sweet courses prepared (7)
21. This sort of room calls for ample space (5)
22. They enable backward-looking people to progress (4)
23. Unusual text seen in conscious condition (8)

DOWN

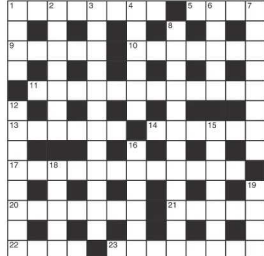
1. Cut down this month in a way (4)
2. A duck that comes to a pointed conclusion (7)
3. The arm kept up one's sleeve (6,6)
4. Capital piece of terra cotta wanted (6)
6. Locking device made in nickel at Charleston (5)
7. Compelling influence of cunning ruler's rise (4)
8. Wager about more fractious hands causing confusion (12)
10. Scotsman going to his doctor is just showing off (6)
12. Decentral base equal to being relatively defensible (7)
16. Field a ball perhaps (6)
18. Imprisoned dog to suffer (5)
19. A heavy blow during the midshipman's watch (4)

YESTERDAY'S SOLUTIONS (17/5/25)



PUZZLE 17560

© Gemini Crosswords 2018 All rights reserved



QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

1. Divert attention of (8)
5. Long arduous journey (4)
9. Encumbered (5)
10. Abbreviate (7)
11. Silly movies comic policemen (8,4)
13. From a confidential source (6)
14. Photographer's workstation (6)
17. Deliberately snub (4-8)
20. Set aside for a purpose (7)
21. A plaster surface for painting (5)
22. City of Homeric legend (4)
23. Semi-dramatic choral work (8)

DOWN

1. Overcast (4)
2. Sorrow (7)
3. Position giving very close view (8,4)
4. Business patronage (6)
6. Proportion (5)
7. Capital of Jamaica (8)
8. Is revealed (5,5)
12. Unobtrusive (8)
15. Kitchen sideboard (7)
16. Worker in a seaport (6)
18. As a very slow tempo (5)
19. Unaccompanied (4)

{ SUDOKU } DIFFICULTY LEVEL ★★



{ WEATHER }

TEMPERATURE HIGH + LOW

MONDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain
29°C | 21°C

TUESDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain
29°C | 22°C

WEDNESDAY Generally cloudy sky with light rain
29°C | 20°C

ALMANAC

Today is 10th August 2026

☀️ Sunny ☁️ Partly cloudy ☔ Rainy 🌧️ Thunderstorm 🌩️

☀️ Sunny ☁️ Partly cloudy ☔ Rainy 🌧️ Thunderstorm 🌩️

☀️ Sunny ☁️ Partly cloudy ☔ Rainy 🌧️ Thunderstorm 🌩️

☀️ Sunny ☁️ Partly cloudy ☔ Rainy 🌧️ Thunderstorm 🌩️

TEMPERATURE IN METROS

Delhi 33°C | 24°C

Mumbai 33°C | 24°C

Kolkata 33°C | 28°C

Chennai 33°C | 27°C

Bengaluru 29°C | 21°C

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

SMARTER FINANCIAL DECISIONS START HERE EVERY WEDNESDAY

INTRODUCING

Hindustan Times YOUR MONEY

PERSONAL FINANCE. MADE SIMPLE.

Better financial decisions begin with better understanding. This weekly series helps you navigate money with greater confidence.



READ EVERY WEDNESDAY



SPORT

Gill's 44 settles India's Test top order jigsaw

The visitors win the 3-day warmup game after the home side's sporting declaration lets Indians bat on the third and final day

Somshuvra Laha
somshuvra.laha@htlive.com

KOLKATA: There was nothing remotely spectacular about Shubman Gill's 44. It was, by the standards of the India captain's career, almost modest — 54 balls, seven fours, and a leading-edge dismissal that shouldn't be read too much into.

Yet, as India completed a six-wicket victory over Sri Lanka in their tour match, Gill's innings carried significance beyond its score.

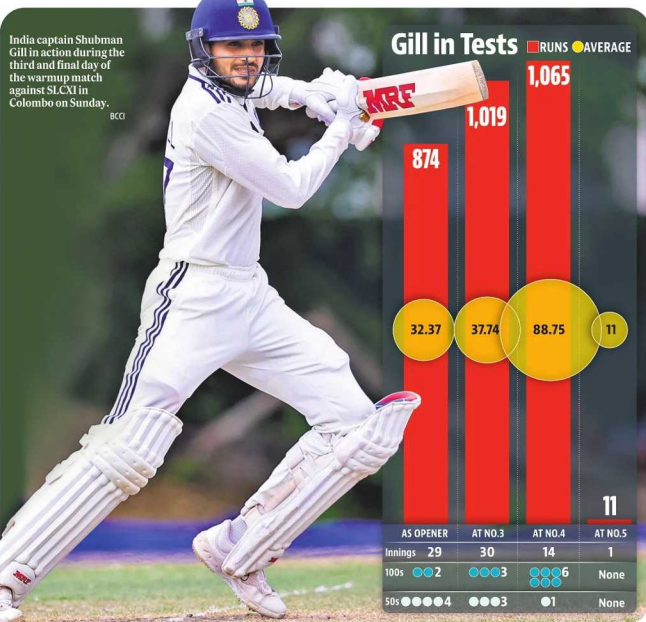
For India, this was less about runs than reassurance. Devdutt Padikkal's hundred on Saturday had already provided one potential answer. Yashasvi Jaiswal's brisk 61 from 46 balls in the second innings added another. Rishabh Pant's batting in the second innings, too, offered familiar evidence of his capacity to change the tempo of an innings.

Then came Gill, back at the crease, back at No. 4, and — most importantly — back looking like a batter who belongs at the centre of India's Test plans. That was the final piece in the batting line-up India needed.

Gill wasn't even certain to bat in the match. He had suffered an impact injury to his right ring finger during a practice session and didn't take the field for the first two days. His decision to return to the nets on Sunday for a rigorous batting session was therefore as much a reassurance as a statement.

India wanted him to spend time in the middle before the Test series begins in Galle on August 15. Gill, too, needed the reassurance that comes only from facing a red ball rather than watching from the dressing room.

He got 54 balls. He also struck across his boundaries with the fluency that has become characteristic of his batting. There was a crisp shot through extra cover off Vishwa Fernando early in the innings. More boundaries in one over from Lahiru Kumara, and later a sweep off Ramesh Mendis that raced to the bound-



India captain Shubman Gill in action during the third and final day of the warmup match against Sri Lanka in Colombo on Sunday.

BCI

ary. The dismissal, to Keshava Nuvuwan, was almost secondary.

The real objective in this tour game was to release the batting order India expect to take into the first Test, on a Nondescripts Cricket Club Ground pitch that somewhat resembles the surface they are likely to get at Galle. That makes Gill's innings particularly valuable. His absence was painfully felt during India's 0-2 defeat to South Africa last year. Gill has generally been capable of turning starts into substantial innings.

That is precisely why India need him. No. 4. The preferred combination appears increasingly clear.

K. Rahul and Jaiswal are expected to open with Padikkal pushing for the No. 3 spot after his hundred in the injured Sai Sudharsan's absence for the tour. Gill slotting back in at four gives

India a blend of experience, left-right variation, aggression and the possibility of sustained accumulation through the top four.

The tour game allowed the Indians to rehearse it without the pressure of a Test. Gill opening in the second innings wasn't necessarily a signal that India are contemplating a change. Rather, it was an opportunity to maximise his time in the middle after he had missed the first two days.

There was another encouraging aspect to his 44. Gill did not appear to be batting as though protecting an injury. He played his shots. He moved across the crease. He drove, swept and rotated the strike. He went from 13 to 29 with three boundaries in quick suc-

cession. The innings eventually slowed as he settled, but that was hardly a concern in a rehearsal whose primary purpose was preparation.

Jaiswal supplied the acceleration India have come to expect from him. His 61 from 46 balls contained nine fours and two sixes and was a reminder that India's left-handed opener can transform a chase before the opposition has time to settle. Sri Lanka's Nishan Madushika, who made fifties in both innings, provided encouragement, while Mohammed Siraj found time to entertain with a late burst of shuffling. But the most consequential runs may have been his skipper's.

PM Modi hosts CWG medallists



Prime Minister Narendra Modi receives a jersey from silver medal winning para shot putter Shubham Juyal in the presence of India's CWG medallists during a felicitation ceremony at his residence in New Delhi on Sunday. Later, the PM tweeted: "Delighted to host our outstanding medal winners from the CWG 2026 at 7, Lok Kalyan Marg. Heard about their experiences from the Games. Each one of them has made our nation proud through their exceptional performances. Their success will motivate many youngsters." During the event, PM Modi offered a sweet to weightlifter Mirabai Chanu, posed with boxer Sakshi Chaudhary, and shared a light moment with para powerlifter Jhanda Kumar. Sakshi said: "Our honourable PM sir has welcomed all the medallists from CWG and we are feeling very proud of this. We have really enjoyed meeting him, he is very humble." Modi, while interacting with the athletes, said: "Jo khelega, woh khiga. Always cheer for Bharat." PMO



Sarfaraz Khan played for CSK in the 2026 IPL.

Sarfaraz recalled for India Tests after a gap of 20 months

HT Correspondent

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

KOLKATA: Sarfaraz Khan was on Sunday named as Sai Sudharsan's replacement for the two-Test series against Sri Lanka, beginning in Galle on August 15, giving the 28-year-old another opportunity to revive an international career that has struggled to find continuity.

Sudharsan, who injured his knee during the India A tour of Sri Lanka last month, is recovering at the BCCI Centre of Excellence in Bengaluru.

Sarfaraz will join the squad in Colombo before travelling to Galle. Yet his inclusion does not necessarily translate into a place in the XI. With Sudharsan unavailable, Devdutt Padikkal is the likelier candidate to occupy the No. 3 position.

The Mumbai batter has played only six Tests since making his debut in 2024, scoring 371 runs at an average of 37.10. His numbers are respectable, if not spectacular, and include a century and three fifties. His defining international innings remains the century 150 against New Zealand in Bengaluru

in October 2024 — an innings that stood out during a home series in which India were eventually swept 3-0.

But despite that performance, Sarfaraz has not played another Test since November 2024. He went on the Australia tour that followed, but didn't get a game, in a series India lost 1-3 and saw Virat Kohli and Rohit Sharma end their Test careers.

Sarfaraz's absence from subsequent squads has been a curious aspect of India's selection story, particularly given his prolific domestic record. He is back in the reckoning with runs behind him. Sarfaraz scored 429 runs in nine innings for Mumbai in the 2025-26 Ranji season, averaging 53.02 with a highest score of 227.

He has not played professional cricket since representing Chennai Super Kings in the IPL in April. He was recently named in West Zone's Duleep Trophy squad. The tournament, scheduled for August 23 to September 10 overlaps with the Sri Lanka series.

Sarfaraz is back in the Test fold. But whether this will finally lead to a regular place in the Test middle order remains a big question.

Ashmita wins Korea Masters for her first BWF World Tour title

Sandip Sikdar

sandip.sikdar@htlive.com

NEW DELHI: There was nothing but absolute focus in the eyes of Ashmita Chahla as she stepped on to the main court of the Yisun Gymnasium in Asan in what was the 26-year-old's first final on the BWF World Tour.

It was Sunday at the \$250,000 Korea Masters and the left-handed shuttler stood on the verge of history. Ranked No. 50 in the world, the Guwahati girl was the underdog. Yet, she carried a quiet, undeniable momentum.

Earlier in the Super 300 tournament, she had stormed through the draw by dismantling top seed Hina Akechi of Japan in the quarter-finals. Now, only China's fourth seed, Han Qian Xi, stood between her and her first BWF World Tour title. But the Chinese couldn't oppose Ashmita for long as the Indian shuttler won 14-21, 21-14, 21-14 to become the first Indian to win the Korea Masters.

It was extra special for Ashmita. A comeback would have been the last thing on her mind during the dark phase after suffering a career-threatening knee injury (medial meniscus tear) in the same tournament in August 2024. Surgery was followed by a lengthy rehabilitation phase when rebuilding confidence as well as fitness and skill was all a huge challenge.

"I feel really great and unbelievable. But then I am trying to digest it. Now, I am hungry for more," Ashmita said, relief and joy evident, as she expressed her gratitude to her Korean coach Park Tae-sang.

The final began with a flash of brilliance. Channelling the rigorous training she had undergone under Park at the National Centre of Excellence in Guwahati, Ash-



India's Ashmita Chahla in action during the final of the Korea Masters.

BADMINTON PHOTO

mita came out swinging. Her smashes found the lines and her deft net play pushed her to an early 9-5 lead.

But arenas have their own unseen variables, and the air currents high above the court began to play tricks. The tricky draft caught the shuttle, distorting its flight path. Ashmita struggled to calibrate her shots.

Frustration mounted as a flurry of unforced errors saw her bleed five straight points. The world No. 35 seized the momentum, capitalising on the shifting conditions to snatch the opening game.

At the interval, Ashmita walked to the sidelines. There, Park was waiting. Where doubt could have easily crept in, her coach offered a vital injection of energy and tactical clarity. As the

players swapped ends for the second game, Ashmita immediately felt the difference. She was now on the "comfortable" side of the court, shielded from the unpredictable draft that had plagued her earlier.

With the handicap lifted, the Indian unleashed her true game. She dictated the pace, moving Han side to side, snapping winners. Controlling the rallies with newfound authority, she mirrored the scoreline of the first game to force a decider.

The third game was a battle of nerves and endurance. Knowing she had to start on the trickier side of the court, Ashmita dug deep. Her strategy shifted from aggressive shot-making to one of patience. She stayed in the long rallies, waiting for the mid-game

interval.

The players switched sides one last time after the interval. Stepping back on to the "good" side, Ashmita knew this was her moment. She turned up the pressure, finding crucial winners when she needed them. She won in 53 minutes.

As the shuttle hit the floor, disbelief washed over her. All the talent and hard work she had put in over the years bore fruition, the magnitude of her achievement still sinking in.

Ashmita is the fifth Indian player to win a BWF World Tour title this year, after PV Sindhu (Japan Open), Satwiksairaj Rankireddy/Chirag Shetty (Singapore Open), Devika Shetty (Thailand Masters) and Tanvi Sharma (Taipei Open).

BCCI to seek govt's nod for white-ball tour of Bangladesh

HT Correspondent

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

MUMBAI: The fate of India's once-postponed white-ball tour of Bangladesh is now contingent on a late thaw in relations between the two countries and the response of the two governments.

The BCCI will seek directions from the Indian government. Only if they give a nod would the tour go ahead, a BCCI official said.

Bangladesh Cricket Board (BCB) has constantly been in touch with the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) ever since former skipper Tamim Iqbal took over as BCB president from Anam Islam Bulbul. And Iqbal badly wants the series to happen.

For the India series, BCB is looking at a window between late August and mid-September. However, the latest turn of political events has left BCB less hopeful. Recently, former Bangladesh PM Sheikh Hasina, currently on exile in India, said she was prepared to face arrest, imprisonment or even death, but would return to her homeland. Bangladesh has asked India for Hasina's extradition.

Government permissions for bilateral series are usually a formality — the only exception being Pakistan — but India-Bangladesh relations also have been particularly strained for more than a year.

India were to originally play a white-ball series (3 T20Is and 3 ODIs) in Bangladesh in 2025, before it was deferred by a year following political tensions between the two countries. At the time, a BCCI statement

INDIA WERE TO ORIGINALLY PLAY A WHITE-BALL SERIES (3 T20IS AND 3 ODIs) IN BANGLADESH IN 2025, BEFORE IT WAS DEFERRED BY A YEAR

had cited "international cricketing commitments and scheduling convenience of both teams" as the reason behind the postponement.

Subsequently, the Bangladesh cricket board instructed IPL franchise Kolkata Knight Riders in January to release Bangladesh fast bowler Mustafizur Rahman from their squad, amid deteriorating relations between the countries, without specifying a reason for the directive. Bangladesh's then sports advisor Asif Nazrul led the demand to move Bangladesh's 2026 T20 World Cup matches out of India.

With the Bangladesh general elections around the corner, the government refused to back down despite discussions with International Cricket Council (ICC). It finally resulted in BCB deciding against playing the World Cup matches in India. Scotland then replaced Bangladesh in the World Cup fixtures. Pakistan moved their matches in Sri Lanka.

U20 Worlds: Basant clinches India's first high jump silver

Basant Kumar Meghwal wins high jump silver and Shahnavaz Khan the long jump bronze at U20 World Athletics

Shantanu Srivastava
sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: Indian athletics has had a productive fortnight. While Neeraj Chopra, Tejaswin Shankar, Murali Sreeshankar and Gulveer Singh exemplified the rapid strides track and field athletes are taking at the big stage — thanks to their success at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games — the next generation is asserting itself at Under-20 World Athletics Championships in Eugene, USA.

Ashish Yadav's silver in javelin on Saturday was followed by the double delight on Sunday with high jumper Basant Kumar Meghwal and long jumper Shahnavaz Khan boosting India's medal tally. Basant won silver and Shahnavaz bronze, the Navyens extending their excellent breakout seasons.

Basant cleared 2.21m to become the first Indian high jumper, male or female of any age-group, to win a World event. The 19-year-old also equalled his personal best that he achieved in April at the National Junior Athletics Federation Competition in Bengaluru. "It's a great feeling. I have been dreaming of this medal for the past two years," he told HT from Eugene.

He told he described as "ideal conditions for jumping". Basant started with 2.06m and progressed to clear 2.12m and 2.17m before attempting 2.21m for the medal.

The top-three cleared 2.21m, which meant the medals were decided on a countback. Algeria's Younes Ayachi won gold after clearing 2.21m on his first attempt. Basant was successful on his second try while Great Britain's Otis Poole took bronze, having nailed the height only in his third attempt.

"I never lost my confidence despite failing to clear the first attempt. My coach (former women's high jump national

India's NextGen rises

The U20 World Athletics Championships has thrown up two jumps stars for India on what turned out to be a memorable weekend for Indian athletics

BASANT KUMAR

Age: 19
From: Anupgarh, Rajasthan
Discipline: High Jump

PERSONAL BEST

2.21m

At World U20 Championships

SEASON'S BEST

2.21m

At World U20 Championships

CAREER HIGHS

Silver at World U20 Champs, Eugene, 2026

Gold at Asian U20 Champs, Hong Kong, 2026

Gold at National Junior Athletics Federation Cup, Bengaluru, 2026

SHAHNAVAZ KHAN

Age: 18
From: Pratappgarh, UP
Discipline: Long Jump

PERSONAL BEST

7.84m

At World U20 Championships

SEASON'S BEST

8.30m

At World U20 Championships

CAREER HIGHS

Bronze at World U20 Champs, Eugene, 2026

Gold at Asian U20 Champs, Hong Kong, 2026

Gold at National Junior Athletics Federation Cup, Bengaluru, 2026

record holder Sahana Kumari) told me to focus on execution, keep down I knew I could do it because I had cleared it once at home. So, I trusted my muscle memory to kick in," Basant said.

His success in Eugene shouldn't really come as a surprise as the youngster has been consistent throughout the season. Out of the six events he has competed in this year, Basant has been on the podium five times. The Eugene silver was preceded by gold at the Asian under-20 meet in Hong Kong in May where he cleared 2.20m. Basant has improved his personal best by 10cm in a year, going from 2.11m to 2.21m.

Hailing from Anupgarh town in Rajasthan's Sri Ganganagar district, Basant comes from a farming family. His father owns a small land patch where the family grows seasonal crops, ranging from mustard, cotton, wheat and bajra. He studied in a government school where high jump caught his fancy.

"I was a very active kid so my PT teacher made me try different sports. I particularly liked high jump." The school had limited means, so Basant got a mattress from his house for the landing mat. "I was clearing 1.80m by the time I was 15. My PT teacher began to enrol me in inter-school meets, and I got my first proper kick when I won the state school games gold medal."

A year later, Basant went to SAI Bengaluru for an entry trial where

he was spotted by Sahana Kumari. "I liked his natural technique, although there was a lot of scope for improvement," she said. Basant couldn't make the cut but Sahana advised him to shift base to Bengaluru and train under her through the 'come-and-play' scheme. The youngster shared a one-room dwelling with a friend outside the SAI campus, but couldn't deal with the loneliness and returned home within a month.

Shortly after, he won the Junior Nationals (U18) and was sent to SAI Bengaluru under the Khelo India scheme in 2023. "He had a bright future. He stands 6'1", has a good technique, and is a quick learner," added Sahana.

Basant, who grew up watching YouTube videos of Qatari high jump legend Mutaz Barshim believes he can clear 2.27m in the near future. "I think I should be able to challenge Sarvesh (Kushare) Bhutiyar in 1.5 years," he said. Kushare's national record is 2.31m. His close friend Shahnavaz continues his rise with a third place. The 18-year-old produced a best leap of 7.84m to finish behind Italy's Daniele Leonardo Inzoli (7.97m) and Australia's Mason McGroder (7.96m). "I am happy to win the medal but not satisfied with the jump. I started cramping on both my calves after the third jump and injured my right heel after the fifth attempt. I could have done 8m otherwise," he said.

DPL: Sarthak, Vikas power North Delhi to 7-wicket win

HT Correspondent

sportsdesk@hindustantimes.com

NEW DELHI: North Delhi Strikers registered a comfortable seven-wicket victory over New Delhi Tigers in DPL at the Arun Jaitley Stadium on Sunday, powered by a captain's knock from Sarthak Ranjan.

Opting to bowl, North Delhi restricted New Delhi to 89/8 in 20 overs. Opener Atulya Pandey gave New Delhi a brisk start with 32 off 21 balls, featuring six boundaries. However, North Delhi kept taking

wickets. Vikas Dhot was the stand-out bowler, breaking partnerships through the middle and death overs to finish with figures of 3/28.

Despite middle-order contributions from skipper Himmat Singh (24 off 17), Aayush Sharma (25 off 21), and Hirshik Shokeen (35 off 25), New Delhi struggled to break free against a disciplined North Delhi attack where all five front-line bowlers — Akhil Chaudhary (1/33), Ajay Yadav (1/32), Arjun Rappia (1/35), Mayank Dagar (1/32), and Vikas Dhot — picked up at least one wicket.

Chasing 162, North Delhi made light work of the target, reaching 165/3 in 12.1 overs. Ranjan led from the front with a masterful 65 off 43 balls, striking three fours and five sixes. Ranjan shared a 102-run opening partnership off 70 balls with Vaibhav Kandpal, who anchored with 41 off 36 deliveries.

Though Ravant Ralayan picked up 2/26 to briefly stall the chase, quickfire cameos from Yash Bhatia (19 off 9), Bharat Sindhwani (24 off 18), and Yash Dabas (14 off 9) guided the North Delhi home with five balls to spare.

HAVE FUN WITH FACTS ON SUNDAYS

{ STRAIGHT DRIVE }
Amrit Mathur

India's growing influence visible over English cricket

India and England go back a long way in cricket, more than a hundred years. In days past, Indian princes led touring teams, now corporate cars own teams in The Hundred. Over the years the nature of contact has changed, moving from cricket to commerce.

At one time, County cricket was considered essential for the growth of players and the best in the world went down its grind. These days concerns of workload management didn't exist and cricketers played all the time. As contracted professionals, bowlers bowled in the nets, sent down 25-30 overs in a day and drove to the next venue after play ended. Nobody wanted rest.

Most Indian batsmen from the previous generation did a stint in England, learning to bat in difficult conditions and improving their skills to handle bounce and seam. But when the international calendar got busy players could not find time for County cricket.

Patuadi, Gavaskar, Kapil Dev, Ravi Shastri, Tendulkar, Dravid and Sourav played for Counties, and recently Pujari, Rahane and Sai Sudarshan spent time in England. This season the bowlers, not batters, are in England — Jaydev Unadkat, Kuldeep Yadav, Sai Kishore, Manav Suthar, Yuzi Chahal, Rahul Chahar. Interestingly, the wheel of cricket has turned a full circle and India is at the core of English cricket — but in a different

way. More than individual players, it is Indian money and the Indian team that is in demand. England realised that each visit of the Indian team leads to a massive commercial boost.

In England, and elsewhere, the Indian team is cricket's box office a guaranteed money spinner. No wonder after a five Test series last year the Indian team was again in England this summer on a white-ball tour. And, yes — all games were sold out. Host venues generated significant profits from ticket sales and top end hospitality packages.

India's shadow over English cricket is growing in a much deeper manner. For the ECB, The Hundred is its financial lifeline because 14 of its 18 Counties are in the red annually. The sale of franchise teams attracted vast amounts of Indian money, which is being funnelled into cricket at different levels.

The biggest play of Indian cricket/corporate clout is visible at Hampshire. Its Southern Bravos Hundred team is fully owned by the GMR Group which also controls Hampshire's County cricket. Elsewhere, IPL franchises (MI, Sunrisers, LSG) not just add their unique colour to the competition, but are part of the governance structure. In Manchester, LSG has announced an ambitious plan to invest in cricket infrastructure.

Unlike India, cricket faces serious challenges in England, not all

of them financial in nature. The major concern is that cricket is unattractive to the youth, even roller skating and darts (not considered sport in India) have more followers. Attracting talent into cricket is a huge task and getting people to buy tickets to watch an even bigger one. Mindful of these ground realities, closer commercial contact with India is seen as the silver bullet to get over the problems.

One interesting development is the rising stature of Indian cricket people within English cricket ecosystem. A notable example is Dinesh Karthik, who is part of the London Spirit Hundred technical leadership group and a regular on the Sky Sports commentary team.

DK successfully transitioned from red to white ball, from Tests to the 20-over circuit, from the dressing room to the television commentary box. DK is the complete package — solid experience, a sharp analytical mind, fluent expression and a pleasant personality. With him on the circuit is Ravi Shastri who has a strong voice and a strong opinion. This year, Aljinkya Rahane took to the microphone, covering three matches for The Hundred.

When asked about his new role, Rahane said he would have liked to do more but had to go rush to Mumbai — because his daughter's school was opening after summer break. That, in today's context, is also workload management.

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE LAST WORD.

EVERYONE HAS A THEORY OURS HAS THE NUMBERS

Hindustan Times NUMBER THEORY

Go beyond opinions with evidence-backed insights that uncover hidden trends, challenge assumptions and reveal a deeper understanding of the stories shaping India and the world.

What is the actual economic inequality in India?

The richly skewed gap between the top 1% and the rest of the population

2. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

3. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

4. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

5. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

6. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

7. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

8. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

9. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

10. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

11. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

12. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

13. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

14. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

15. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

16. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

17. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

18. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

19. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

20. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

21. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

22. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

23. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

24. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

25. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

26. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

27. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

28. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

29. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

30. How much of the country's GDP is generated by the top 1%?

Jannik Sinner withdraws from Cincinnati Open with knee injury

PARIS: World number one Jannik Sinner has pulled out of the Cincinnati Open due to a right knee injury, the Italian announced Sunday. "After consulting with my doctors and my team, I have to announce that I need to withdraw from the Masters 1000 tournament in Cincinnati," he said in a statement posted on the ATP website. "My right knee has been bothering me and even though we have been working hard with my medical team, I have to accept that I'm not ready to compete yet." The tournament begins on Thursday.

BCCI will look into move Duleep Trophy final to stadium: Saikia

BANGALURU: BCCI secretary Devajit Saikia on Sunday said the board will look into relocating this season's Duleep Trophy final from the Centre of Excellence to a stadium, and revealed that the number of live-telecast domestic matches has been increased to give fans an opportunity to watch more action in real-time. The 2025-27 domestic season will begin with the Duleep Trophy, which is scheduled between Aug 23 and Sept 10 at the BCCI CoE. However, spectators are not allowed inside the CoE and Saikia promised a rethink.

Catch the latest column of
HT TWTW
THE WEEK THAT WAS
A quiz on the week's development.

